

PREFACE

What the tradition calls the Other Side is two different things wearing one name.

The first is the underside of the Tree. Every station of the Tree is formed by cutting something off, and what it cuts off does not vanish; it settles beneath that same station as the Qliphoth. The old maps chart this by pairing each holy power with a dark one: the filth the Kabbalist fought below the world. None of this is foreign. It is what the Tree leaves behind, the price of each division it made, disowned and given the name of an enemy.

The second was never the Tree's at all. No map holds it, because every map has the shape of a Tree, while this precedes any Tree. The principle of oneness cut itself out of this and spent its whole descent ranking it below the One. Orthodox Kabbalah buried it. The Left-Hand Path that turned toward the dark took the first thing for the second, worked the back of the Tree, and called it the primordial.

We run through Kabbalah because it gave oneness its most exact form, and we argue against modern philosophy and some Left-Hand Path currents, which come near this ground. We affirm one thing at the end, once the ground is cleared, and offer no throne to arrive at and no ladder to climb, only a way of seeing what oneness sealed and the one move left unmade.

This book belongs to a longer work and rests on its ontology; read alone, it asks for that much on trust.

CHAPTER I. ATELOPHILIA

In the houses Teresa of Calcutta founded, the poor of the city came in off the street to be washed, fed, and kept company while they died. She

gave her life to this. She did not grow rich, did not look away from what most people cannot bear to see. The work was genuine and the cost to her was real. Whatever else comes into question here, the sincerity does not, and the argument falls apart the instant she is made a hypocrite.

Look at what the mercy was for. Her houses were not hospitals, and they did not try to be. A hospital exists to remove pain; the work there is aimed at the day the patient leaves cured. Her houses were built on a different premise. The suffering of the poor was held to be precious, a way into the passion of Christ. This is the doctrine of redemptive suffering, a Catholic teaching given its modern statement in *Salvifici Doloris*: pain joined to the cross carries salvation in it. The pain was doing spiritual work; the point was to accompany it and consecrate it, to sit with it to the end. Curing pain would have emptied it of the very thing that made it holy.

The point is not that Teresa failed to love the poor and loved their poverty instead, the charge laid against her. This stays at the level of motive, a private failing of one woman, and leaves the principle untouched. What is shown here is the core of that love.

The mercy is bound to the suffering by what this love is. One love gives to the one who lacks, and its gift answers that lack in the person it reaches, a lack of comfort, of understanding, of company, of means. A love of this kind is constituted by the deficiency it bears on, its motion the meeting of a want in the other. A beloved without lack leaves it no gift to give and nowhere to land. Mercy therefore has a stake in the incompleteness of the world as the condition of its being: complete the world, leave no one wanting, and mercy has been emptied of what it was. Turned toward the complete and self-sufficient, Teresa's love would answer nothing, and would no longer be love.

Widen the frame and this shape appears everywhere the good organizes around a deficit. The student kept a little in ignorance keeps

the teacher a teacher; the savior needs the lost to stay lost. Each is a relation of care constituted by the want it answers, and would lose its role once the want was met. What holds for one act hardens at the scale of an institution. A single act of mercy can end when its object is restored; an order built to give mercy is a mercy made permanent, and it carries the stake the act carried only as a relation, now set into an institution that must continue. The helping profession meant to become unnecessary keeps the client returning, the want renewed appointment by appointment, for an institution of care that has finished its work would have to stop being.

A different love would end here without loss. It wills the completion of the one it holds and takes its joy in the arrival of it, the parent glad at the child grown whole, the friend who hopes to be needed less. That love releases its object when the want is met, and for just that reason no lasting order can be built from it, since an order that dissolves the moment it succeeds is no order. The love these systems raise is not of that kind. It is the one fed by the breach, and it is built to last because the breach does not close.

The words we have for good love all insist it asks no return. *Agape* is the love that gives without return, descending from God to the unworthy. *Caritas* is charity, the same downward grace in Latin dress. *Altruism*, the modern coinage, names regard for the other in place of the self. Each word is built to say that love takes nothing from the one it loves. That is what the case denies. Teresa's mercy needs its object to stay afflicted and lives on the affliction.

Atelēs is the unfinished, what has not reached its *telos*, its completion. *Atelophilia* is the love whose object must stay incomplete. A finished thing, healed and self-sufficient, has no need of the giver, and the relation ends. Suffering is the most visible shape the incompleteness takes, which is why it draws the eye first, but the gap can be empty of pain.

The same requirement extends beyond the level of a single person. The systems that organize salvation for entire civilizations carry it at their foundation. Christianity requires the Fall; a nature arriving complete has no need of salvation; the cross and redemption lose their object. Islam rests on creaturely submission, Judaism on the world's unredeemed exile; the lack is named differently, but the dependence is identical. Buddhism begins from *dukkha*, the unsatisfactoriness of conditioned existence, and makes release possible. Each names a lack and rests its highest good on the lack staying in place. Remove it and the salvation loses its object.

Even where the salvation arrives, the lack stays. The creature is drawn up toward God and set below, near and lesser, always short of the wholeness reserved above it and never allowed to reach it. Salvation confirms atelophilia and makes it permanent. The saved go on wanting a wholeness held above them, and learn to call that wanting their blessedness.

The theory of the lack runs through everything the West has thought about evil, and it begins with Plotinus. The One overflows. The procession carries the light outward and downward, thinning it as it goes, each level farther from the source and holding less of it. At the far end the light gives out, and matter remains: the faintest emanation, a dim residue left where the procession lost its force. Evil for Plotinus is *steresis*, privation, the absence of good. It has no independent nature.

Augustine brought this idea into Christianity as *privatio boni*. Evil is the good gone missing, the corruption of a nature that was made complete and has turned away. The will that sins turns toward the deficient, away from the fullness that would repair it. Salvation is the return: the creature drawn back toward the source. Evil stands aside, having no purpose and no contribution to make.

This cannot reach atelophilia. Pain, hunger, grief are felt and present, each thick with a distinct quality, and none is the bare not-being. The

lack mercy meets is a positive condition in the sufferer, and a love bound to it rests on something real. Privation grants the lack no such weight and cannot ground a love that lives on it. For a good to depend on a lack this way, the lack must carry an independent weight.

The privation theory moves between two senses of non-being and survives by not keeping them apart. If evil is absolute non-being, then nothing follows from it; it cannot be suffered or overcome, because there is nothing there to bear a relation. Absolute nothing has no shape by which it could be filled. If evil is a privation in a subject, then it is no longer absolute nothing. Sickness is not nothing in general; it is the loss of order in a living body. Sin is a determinate disorder of the will. In each case the lack is relative to a bearer and an order that says what ought to have been there. The lack has a place and effects.

Privationism calls evil nothing when it wants to deny evil a positive root, but it treats evil as a determinate lack whenever it has to explain how evil works. Atelophilia exposes the equivocation. The lack required by mercy and redemption is a relative non-being, a not-A that belongs to the structure of A and helps to sustain it.

Kabbalah inherits this downward grammar from Neoplatonism: the light falls from God toward the world, and imperfection appears where the descent reaches its limit. Yet it adds what the theory of privation could not supply: a second side, and with it, the weight of the lack. Evil gathers as *the Qliphoth*, the shells, an order set against the Tree along its full length, with a substance the emanation did not thin into being and cannot draw back. Here lies the weight atelophilia needed and privation had nowhere to put.

One strand of tradition never settled on this weight. The Ma'arekhet ha-Elohut kept the Neoplatonic verdict intact, holding that evil has no objective reality and is purely relative, that it arises from man's failure to receive the full influx of the good and comes to no more than a negative deficiency, an estrangement from the source. Read that way

Kabbalah adds little to Plotinus, and the lack stays weightless. The strand that matters here is the other one, which the Gerona kabbalists and the Zohar made dominant. There evil takes a positive root. The Bahir names Gevurah "a quality whose name is evil," and Isaac the Blind draws the conclusion that a real root of evil and death is balanced against the root of life; pure judgment, severed from the mercy that tempered it, spills out the dark side the way a full vessel spills what it cannot hold. This is evil with being, an order the emanation deposited and cannot simply draw back. The two readings run side by side through the literature and neither drives the other out. We take the tradition at its strongest, where the dark has weight.

CHAPTER 2. EMANATION

Kabbalah draws the descent in which evil has its place, from the hidden source down to the husks at the bottom, and gives the cure a name. Among the systems that set a lack at the root of things, it is the one that diagrams being as the gathering of all difference back into the One, and that draws, on the same sheet, the outside where the gathering gives out.

Kabbalah is the mystical tradition of Judaism. Its question is how a hidden and infinite God comes into relation with a finite world, and it reads scripture and creation together as a single disclosure of that concealed source, unfolding gradually into everything. The word means "received." The teaching is held to pass from master to student through a chain that reaches back to revelation, taken on that authority rather than built up from argument.

The Tree of Life is its central figure. Ten *Sephiroth*, the stations through which the infinite light descends and the world is constituted, are joined by twenty-two paths into one diagram; three veils of the concealed are above the highest; the shells lie below the lowest. The paths are channels between the Sephiroth, each a route along which

the light passes from one station to the next, and the practitioner who works the Tree travels them as much as he dwells in its stations.

Nowhere is the Tree argued for. The ten Sephiroth come as the ten utterances by which the world was spoken, or the ten names of God, or the ten garments the infinite puts on; the three veils above them come as revealed degrees of the hidden; and the question why ten and three, or why this order, is met with an inheritance. The map is given.

What follows keeps faith with the content of that inheritance and parts from it on one point. Where the tradition shows the Tree, the logic of it is drawn out: each station as a step the one before makes necessary, each veil as a move the infinite cannot skip on the way to becoming a source. The version is Lurianic in its account of emanation, Zoharic in its account of the shells, and Neoplatonic underneath, because Kabbalah thinks again in Hebrew what Plotinus thought about the One: the overflow, the procession, and the long dimming into matter. Read this way the Tree stops being a list of names and becomes a single descent, each level produced by the level above.

Begin before any beginning. *Ain Soph*, the Without-End, is the infinite taken with no limit at all. It cannot be the first being, as a being is something bounded, marked off from what it is not, and what has no end has no edge. The infinite therefore cannot simply occupy the head of the Tree as its topmost item. It has to become a source, and that takes three steps, which the tradition draws as three veils. For the limitless to be an origin, it must first be set apart from everything bounded that will flow from it, and the only thing wholly unlike the bounded is nothing: *Ain*, the first veil, the infinite seen as no-thing. But a bare nothing originates nothing. The nothing must be taken as infinite, a fullness and not a blank: *Ain Soph*, the second veil, the nothing without limit. And an infinite fullness still does not pour until it inclines toward pouring and becomes light gathered at the verge of overflow: *Ain Soph Aur*, the limitless light, the third veil. Origination

requires all three steps: severance from the bounded, then fullness, then the inclination to give. This is the negative theology Plotinus reached by setting the One beyond being, *epekeina tes ousias*: the dark Without-End, unreachable by any name.

From the light at the verge, the first thing to emanate is the first limit. *Kether*, the Crown, is what the infinite becomes when it takes its initial bound: not yet anything in particular, the bare fact that now there is something. This first something is *the One*. Kether is pure unity, the Plotinian One at the head of all that descends, the point before any division. Kether is will before there is anything willed, the "that it is" before any "what." Its indeterminacy is undividedness: there is nothing vague in it, no second thing to oppose a first. Everything the Tree will become is here without distinction, and everything that descends from here comes as a departure from this unity and a candidate for return to it. Kether is the least determinate of the Sephiroth.

A point that only *is* must next be something, and the first content is direction: not yet a divided world, but the whole of what will come, flashed out at once. *Chokhmah*, Wisdom, is that outflash, the seminal point of everything to be, held in a single unparted blaze. Wisdom contains all and draws no distinctions. It is the answer to a question Kether could not answer alone, the question of what the bare "it is" is going to be.

An undivided all is still indistinguishable from nothing. There must be something that draws the first distinctions and sets one thing apart from another. *Binah*, Understanding, is the dividing power, the womb where the seminal point is taken in and brought to term as a world of distinct things. Wisdom gives the undivided seed; Understanding draws the boundaries that let the seed become many. With Binah the basic machine of emanation is complete: a source, an undivided content, and the division that makes content into objects.

Here is the first place the necessity leans on something it does not announce. Understanding divides, and the division could in principle run loose, difference proliferating with no counterforce drawing it back. The doctrine binds division to return: Binah divides what is to be gathered again, every distinction made to be balanced and returned upward to the unity. That the many are for the sake of returning to the one is not forced by the logic of division alone. The whole Tree rests on this assumption, laid down early enough to read as necessity. The rest of the descent is the unfolding of that single buried decision.

Between the dividing power and what flows from it lies a station both counted and struck out: *Daath*, Knowledge, the place where Wisdom and Understanding would join. Drawn on some diagrams, absent from the ten on most, it is named here and left in that suspended place. The absence has a reason that cannot be given yet without breaking the order of the account.

What divides must now be governed, because division left alone gives only a scatter of distinct things and not a world. The next Sephiroth are the forces that govern it. *Chesed*, Loving-kindness, is the first: the giving that pours outward without measure, the impulse to extend and grant without limit. The opening showed this at work; here it appears in its place as a principle. Left alone, Chesed would give beyond all form, dissolving boundaries Binah drew, an indulgence so total it unmakes all the distinctions.

Loving-kindness calls up its check. *Gevurah*, Severity, is the power that limits: judgment, which says "this much and no further," the force that draws the line and defends it. Where Chesed includes, Gevurah excludes and denies. And severity alone is as ruinous as mercy, cutting until nothing is left standing, a rigor that withholds the world out of existence. Two principles, each correcting the other and fatal if unrestrained.

These forces require a third that holds them in proportion. *Tipheret*, Beauty, is that holder, the balance that takes giving and withholding and keeps each from running to its ruinous end. Beauty is harmony, the balanced ratio between mercy and severity that lets a world endure, giving enough to exist and limit enough to keep shape. It sits at the heart of the Tree where the opposition is reconciled, and everything now descends from a struck balance.

Below the reconciling center the same logic runs out toward the world in lower key. *Netzach*, Endurance, is the persistence that carries a thing forward against what would stop it. *Hod*, Splendor, is the yielding counterpart, the surrender that lets form be received. Their lower opposition echoes the high one of mercy and severity, pitched now toward action rather than constitution. *Yesod*, the Foundation, gathers all the flows above it and channels them to a single point of transmission, the funnel where the whole Tree narrows before its last step into the world.

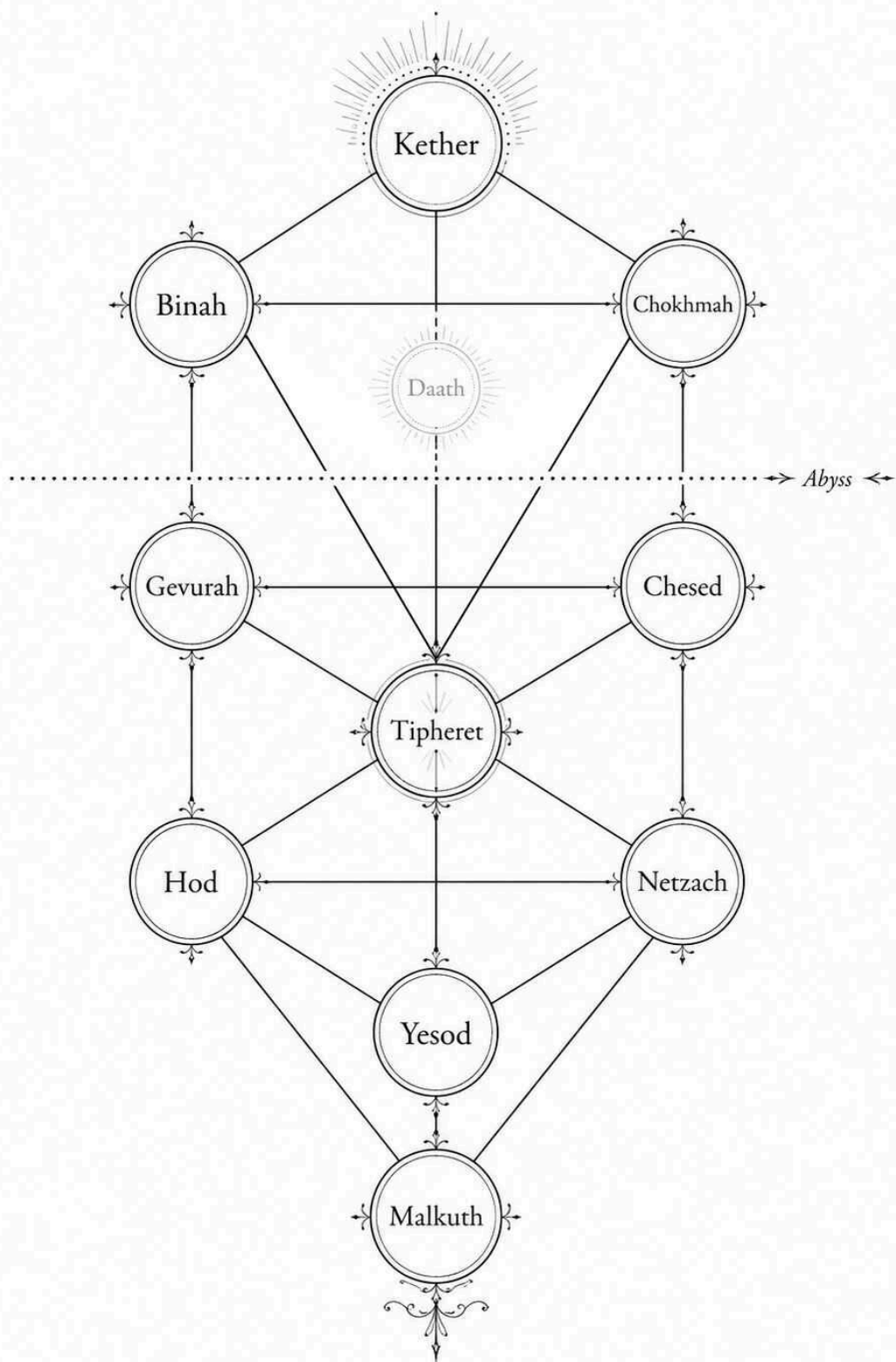
Last, *Malkuth*, the Kingdom, adds no force. It is the pure vessel, receiving everything the nine above pour down and gathering it at the floor of the Tree. This floor is the made world, the cosmos as the settling-place of all that the Tree let fall, and what lies just beneath it is the husk. Malkuth is the one Sephirah that originates nothing, the bottom where the light, having passed through every limit, arrives at its faintest.

The descent traces a zigzag from crown to kingdom, right to left and down, the path called the lightning flash, and across it stand three pillars: mercy on the right, severity on the left, the reconciling column between them. Read along its length, the one Tree divides into the four worlds, set to YHWH, the four letters of the divine name. *Atzilut* is Kether alone, the Yod, the bare source before it has said what it is. *Beriah* takes Chokhmah and Binah, the outflash and the power that divides it, the first Heh, the throne. Below these two worlds the Abyss

opens. *Yetzirah* holds the six that govern a world, Chesed down to Yesod, the Vav whose number is theirs. *Asiyah* is Malkuth, the Heh that closes the name, the made cosmos itself.

The four worlds are the one Tree told as stages of a single name: source and throne above the Abyss, the governing forces and the vessel below. The division seats the descent in a cosmos and gives its parts a place. Ours is the last, *Asiyah*, the cosmos we inhabit, where the light in Malkuth has worn to its faintest and the shells lie just under the threshold of the made world. With the name closed at that floor, the Neoplatonic account of imperfection is built into the frame of things: distance from the source measures deficiency, and what goes wrong keeps its address at the bottom.

But if distance alone explains the flaw, the flaw should spread through the whole descent, thickening at every step. Kabbalah will instead locate the break at a single stroke.



CHAPTER 3. CONTRACTION

For the infinite to pour, there must be somewhere for the pouring to go, and the Without-End leaves no void. It is everywhere, with no edge and no outside, no vacancy in which a thing apart from it could arise. The first act of emanation is therefore a withdrawal. The infinite contracts, draws its presence back from a point within itself and leaves an emptiness. The *tzimtzum* names this contraction and it bends the Plotinian overflow out of true. The procession opens with a self-exile.

The emptiness is the *chalal*, the void, the only emptiness there is, since everywhere outside it the infinite remains entire. A trace stays behind in it, the *reshimu*, a remnant of the light that had filled the space before the withdrawal. Into the cleared void a single ray descends from the infinite, the *kav*, building the worlds along its length. The Sephiroth take form on this ray, vessels shaped to hold the light pouring into them, each principle a container for the measure of light it carries.

The upper vessels hold. Kether, Chokhmah, and Binah remain near the source, undivided enough to bear the light. The triad maps onto Plotinus almost exactly: Kether is the One, the source before all division; Chokhmah and Binah together are *Nous*, the divine intellect, where the undivided flash is parted into the first distinctions, thought thinking and in that act positing difference. Difference enters at the second stage, in *Nous*, with the One left above it; multiplicity is the work of intellect, downstream of a unity. The return is this order run backwards, the derived gathered home into the prior.

Lower down the vessels are more separate, and separateness is weakness. The seven vessels below the supernal three were meant to hold the inflowing light, and they could not. The light came, and they shattered. Luria names this *shevirat ha-kelim*, the breaking of the vessels: the cosmos split in the act of being filled.

The light descends and thins as it falls, and the vessels grow more fragile at every remove until it meets vessels too separate and too far to contain it. What makes a world of distinct things possible is the dividing of the light, and that same separateness is what cannot hold.

When that happened, most of the light returned upward to its source. Fragments fell. Shards of the broken vessels descended below the structure, and sparks of the light, the *nitzotzot*, clung to the shards as they fell, caught in the wreckage and carried down with it. The shards with their trapped sparks came to rest beneath Malkuth, and there they are the Qliphoth: broken matter with holy light imprisoned inside it. They settle into a dark structure below the Tree, the domain of the shells, *the Sitra Achra*, the Other Side.

The Zohar gives them their name and their image: *kelipot*, husks, the peel that covers and conceals what is holy. Under Luria the husk is the fallen shard, holding its spark from return. The shells form a separate order, an anti-structure shadowing the Sephiroth, each Sephirah paired across the whole map with the Qliphah that apes and opposes it.

Against the scattering, the work of return begins. *Tikkun*, repair, is the gathering of the fallen sparks, the freeing of the trapped light from the shells and its lifting back toward the top. An act done rightly raises a spark; the broken vessels are mended as the light returns to them; and the cosmos moves back toward repair. The Neoplatonic return, the *epistrophe*, appears here as procession reversed: the many scattered in the fall are gathered again into the One. Departure and repair are one motion read in two directions, and the return gives the departure its meaning.

The assumption set down at Binah comes into its full force here: that the many are made to be returned, that division is an exile carrying its homecoming inside it. The drama of breaking and repair runs on it. The light goes out to come back; the vessels break to be mended; the

sparks fall only to be raised. Difference is the wound, unity is the cure, and the work of the world is the curing.

The breaking fell on the seven lower vessels and spared the supernal three. Malkuth alone, the lowest Sephirah, borders the shells directly, touching the Sitra Achra. The Neoplatonic picture is now complete: the cosmos as a graded descent from the source, each level fainter than the one above, and at the farthest remove the light meets what is nearest to non-being, the formless, the material almost-nothing where Plotinus located deficiency. Evil is a distance, the dimming that sets in as procession runs out of reach of the One. The orthodox reading makes the imperfection local. It is the bottom of the descent, where the light is faintest. Malkuth is imperfect because it borders the Qliphoth, and tikkun is the visit paid to that wound to close it. The machinery of repair rests on it: that the flaw can be located and undone.

This reading sees a symptom and calls it the disease. The doctrine sets the flaw at Malkuth because it has left no other place to set it. Defect cannot be charged to a Sephirah, for the Sephiroth are the structure of God and must remain pure; the imperfection is driven past the lowest of them and lodged in the husks beneath, the one region ranked outside the emanations. The doctrine finds the flaw where it was deposited from the start and concludes the flaw lives only there. Yet a vessel is a limit cut from the limitless, and a Sephirah is a bounding of what had no bound, and each lays down the underside its bounding cast off. The husks heaped at Malkuth's border are that underside, the Tree's disowned constitution, gathered at one end and called alien filth.

CHAPTER 4. THE CATEGORIES

The received teaching gives the ten and asks no further. They descend in their order because that is the order received; that they fall as they fall is taken on the authority of those who know. But the map can be

read as a deduction, each station made necessary by the one before it, and read that way the Tree shows what it is: the self-unfolding of unity into multiplicity through the categories any thought must use to move from one to many. Plotinus drew the descent from the One through Nous to Soul. Plato gives the genera on which the descent can be read: in *the Sophist*, Same and Other among the greatest kinds; in *the Philebus*, Limit, the Unlimited, and the Mixed that arises when measure enters the unlimited. The Sephiroth are those categories, set in their order of generation.

Each category is posited, proves unable to hold alone, and in failing posits the next; the descent is forced by the poverty of the station above it. This is the dialectical engine, the determination driven beyond its limit by what it cannot contain, and the Tree is that engine set upright. To read the ten as a deduction is to follow a category to the insufficiency that hands it to the one below.

Begin at the head. Kether is unity, posited as source and goal. It holds no content, for content is distinction and none has yet been drawn; it is the bare positing of the One to which all is meant to climb back.

From unity, its first determination. The One, to be at all, must first be self-identical before it can face what is other, and that self-sameness is its first content. Chokhmah is the undivided flash, all that will be. It is the category of the same, *tauton*, the One taken without internal difference, a blaze in which everything coincides. Wisdom includes all and distinguishes nothing.

The same, to be the same of anything, requires the other. Identity calls up difference by necessity: Binah is that difference, *thateron*, the dividing power that makes the first distinction, this not-that. Chokhmah and Binah are the categorial pair same-and-other, and together they are Nous, the intellect in which difference first enters being. Scholem records that the Neoplatonic kabbalists, Azriel of Gerona chief among them, laid the descent from the One onto the

Sephiroth and set the first stations as the intellectual grade, *ha-muskal*, above a psychic grade and a natural one below. Idel finds the same in the reading of the first Sephiroth as intellectual processes, Wisdom and Understanding among them, the hypostases of the Tree taken as the acts of a mind. What we draw out as Nous, the sources already treated as the mind's own region. Scholem calls the mapping an artificial compromise with Neoplatonic ontology, and the caution is fair: the fit is read onto the Sephiroth and not confessed by them. The point is the reading they kept reaching for, that the upper Tree is where intellect does its dividing work, whatever compromise the mapping cost.

Identity and difference have arisen, opposed and joined, and their joining is a thing in its own right: the relation in which same and other are held together, neither collapsed into bare identity nor scattered into bare difference. That relation has a place prepared for it on the Tree, between the supernal pair and what descends from them, and the diagram sets nothing in it. The station where this harmony would belong is left empty. Leave the gap open for now.

A difference that only tells this from that is inert, sorting concepts and moving nothing. For difference to bear on a world it must pass from kind into degree, from this-not-that into more-and-less, and degree is intensity. With that the categories leave the domain of form and enter the register of force, and the first form of degree is sheer extension: the impulse to give out and pour past any limit. Chesed is the unlimited, the *apeiron*, the principle of boundless expansion, mercy as the yes that grants without measure. Carried to its purity, it is ruinous, dissolving distinctions Binah drew.

The unlimited calls up limit. Gevurah is *peras*, the bounding principle, the power that cuts and holds the form against its dissolution. Taken to its extreme, it is equally ruinous, limiting until nothing is left to bound. The pattern holds: a principle carried to its completion throws off the opposite that must check it.

Two principles, each fatal alone, require a third that proportions them. Tipheret is the mixed, *to mikton*, the harmony of limit and limitless, the measure in which boundless giving and bounding severity are held in the ratio that lets a world cohere. Beauty is this proportion, and it is where the first opposition is reconciled. Note the kind of reconciling it is: a synthesis that holds the two within a higher unity, mercy and severity composed into one balanced thing. Tipheret is permitted and central because its harmony stays inside the One, gathering the opposites up. Hold this beside the empty station above it. One harmony the Tree builds and crowns; another it leaves unbuilt. The distinction between the harmonies that are allowed and those that are excised is the Tree's governing idea.

The mixed secures a world that coheres, and coherence alone is not yet a world. For things to exist they must affect one another, and constitution must pass into operation. Below the reconciled center the categories run again in the register of act. What was limit and limitless among the world-founding forces becomes, among the world-acting ones, the polarity of doing and being-done-to. Netzach is activity, *poiein*, the outward press, the force that imposes form and drives it forward. Hod is its counterpart, *paschein*, the receptivity that yields to shaping. The pair repeats Chesed and Gevurah an octave down, pitched now toward operation: transactions of the world, the giving and receiving. Each alone is as incomplete as expansion or limit alone; activity without a receiver acts on no one, and reception without an agent receives no form.

What the lower pair requires is a third that holds it, as Chesed and Gevurah required Tipheret. Yesod is that third, the reconciliation of the act-register. Where Tipheret fused limit and limitless into a proportion, a single balanced state, the act-pair binds into an exchange, each thing that acts being at once acted upon. Yesod holds them as that reciprocity, relation as the mutual binding of doer and done-to. The category has no independent content and lives only in

what it relates; Aristotle named it *pros ti*, and Kant gave it its purest form as community, *Gemeinschaft*, the reciprocal action in which each term is agent to the other and patient to it at once. The whole reciprocity is turned downward: Yesod is the funnel that collects the flows above and passes them to the vessel below, the foundation through which they are delivered into Malkuth. Tipheret gathers its opposites by composing them into one; Yesod gathers its own by conveying them, and both stay within unity, each a harmony of powers the descent bends toward the One.

Malkuth is the vessel in which the categories arrive, the place where the deductive descent sets into a world. In Malkuth the categorial machine surfaces, the abstract determinations precipitate into the made cosmos, and the cosmos turns its one face toward the husk beneath it.

The descent read this far shows why the lower vessels give way. In Nous the difference is formal, a species held under a genus, thateron drawn by Binah and kept in view of the same it divides. Difference of that order the light gathers back without loss, abstraction folding the many into the one it was drawn from.

Below the supernal pair the difference changes rank. It leaves the realm of ideas and enters the domain of force that bears on something. A question opens here that the supernal triad never raised: Chesed pours upon objects, sorts the worthy from the needy, lays measure on a manifold, and the manifold was not made above. The triad divided only its internal unfolding and produced no material for force to work. The objects enter from below Nous, from outside the axis of the descent, and the account cannot yet say where they come from. A genus reclaims its species because it drew the species from itself; the light has no way to reclaim foreign material, never having emanated it. The vessel that would contain this carries a difference the unity did not produce and cannot draw back. That is where it gives way. Lurianic

language names this giving way a breaking and sets it at the weak vessels far from the source; read through the categories, it is the point where the light meets a difference it can bound and never gather. The failure sits in the passage from formal to applied, at the seam below Nous, and it is there by the logic of the descent and not by an accident.

Taken together, the descent is the One unfolding through same and other, limit and limitless, and the mixtures and transmissions these require, until it arrives at the vessel that receives them all. The engine is the oldest in metaphysics. It is Plotinus, the One overflowing into Nous and Soul and drawing them back in the return. It is Hegel, the concept positing its other, suffering the contradiction, and lifting both into a higher unity that keeps them as its moments. A negation is a stage on the way to a fuller One: the Tree is the Logic drawn vertically, the dialectic with Kether where the Absolute belongs. And the necessity that drives it is borrowed. It is the necessity of return, present only because a unity was set as the end.

The Tree carries out its deduction: difference and opposition are permitted as phases, each contradiction generated to be resolved, the motion bent toward the One. Remove the One from the head and the categories still arise, but no force compels their return, and that machine that drove everything back toward unity will stop. What this leaves no room for is a difference that does not resolve. Whether anything could remain unreturned, the descent cannot say, as it was built from the start to bring everything home.

CHAPTER 5. THE CASE FOR THE ONE

Unity now deserves its strongest defense, as the case for the primacy of the One is not a prejudice to be brushed aside. It is among the oldest and hardest claims philosophy has made, and most of what has been thought well was thought inside it.

To be is to be something, and to be something is to be one. A thing that is not one thing is not a thing at all; it is either nothing or a heap, and a heap is real only in its members, each of which is again one. Scholastic metaphysics fixed this in a formula it took as bedrock: *ens et unum convertuntur*, being and unity convert, every being is one and whatever is one has being.

To lose unity is to lose existence in the same motion. A world, a self, a thing persists just so long as it holds together as one and dissolves when it stops. Multiplicity does not threaten this; the many are simply many ones, and each owes its being to the unity it has. Difference, on this account, is always a difference between unities and within a unity that frames it. Take unity away and nothing is left to differ.

Another argument is from value. Good is a gathering, evil is a scattering. Health is the parts of the body working as one; sickness is a faction breaking from the whole. A soul is well when its powers align and ill when they pull apart; a city stands when its citizens will together and falls into civil war when they divide. For the Greeks, the good is what all things desire, and what they desire is completion, which is their gathering into the one they are meant to be.

For Plotinus the One is the Good as such, and the descent from it is the fall into greater division, greater distance from the source; evil is the privation that sets in as unity thins out. To be good is to return, to be lifted back toward the One. To be evil is to fall apart. On this reading any purpose whatsoever is a movement toward unity, and a thing that willed pure division would be willing its undoing, which is to say willing nothing, since there would be no one left to have willed it.

To think is to gather a manifold into one. A perception that did not unite its moments would perceive nothing; a judgment that did not hold subject and predicate in one act would judge nothing; a self that did not bind its experiences into one consciousness would not be a self to whom anything appeared. Kant found at the root of all cognition the

unity of apperception, the single "I think" that must accompany any representation, without which the manifold of sense would be less than a dream, an unowned scatter belonging to no one. Before Kant, Parmenides had said that thought and being are the same, and what is, is one, and the many and the moving are the way of seeming, not the way of truth. To think the many is already to have unified it into a thinkable many. There is no thought of sheer difference, because to think difference is to hold its terms together in one regard, and that is unity at work. The One stands as the condition under which there is anything to be said at all.

Each argument supports the next: thought requires unity; being is one; the good, which is being's completion, is unity recovered. To oppose this looks like opposing sense as such, against the very conditions under which anything determinate could be said. The defender of the One can rest here and seem to have won the ground entirely.

Take the first two arguments at the word on which they turn. Both run on "one," and it carries two senses the case lets slide together. There is one as unit, the count by which a thing is one thing at all, a self that holds or comes apart. And there is One as Unity, the source before all division, gathering everything home. The dissolution argument earns the first sense and is handed the second. That a thing must cohere as a unit to exist is granted in full. It reaches nowhere near the Unity set first and made the end. The slide appears where the argument names its remainder. To be one unit is to be one thing counted off from the rest, bounded, set as this against what it is not; the marking off is a difference already drawn. The case concedes it in passing: the many are simply many ones. Difference sits with unity at the root of a thing's being one, the ground on which counting to one is possible at all. What the argument still owes is the frame. Grant a unit its unity and there is a field of ones, each one among others. To call that field One is a further act the dissolution argument does not fund, since the

coherence a unit needs is the unit's own, drawn from the very others it faces.

The value argument carries this debt too. Health gathers a body, with other bodies around it, and the good of gathering is the good of an individuated one resting on its manifold. That gathering is good for a unit and tells us nothing of a Unity to which it must climb back. What binds a manifold is internal coherence, owing nothing to a One set above it. Press the monist's last move, that the field of ones is one field after all, and it comes apart in the hand. Counted, the one field is one among the fields that might have been marked instead, a unit like its members, carrying no primacy. Raised to a Unity over the members, it is the thing to be proved.

The same law reaches the third argument, the case's firmest ground. What held of the unit holds of thought, which is determinate like anything else, and nothing is thought except by the not that bounds it. To think is not only to hold predicates together in one act; it is to appear as a thinker over against the thought, an "I" marked off from what it thinks. The unity of apperception that was to be the root of all synthesis is already a cut, the subject severed from its object before any manifold is gathered, a severance the argument uses and never counts. Turn this move on the One. To think the One is to hold it as this and not another, bounded by the not-One; the act meant to prove unity first has laid a difference beneath it. A One with nothing to differ from is the blank set above Kether and could not think. Difference is what any unity is drawn from, spent wherever a one is thought.

Only one retreat is left. The One lies past everything thought can reach, the defender says; it is placed *epekeina tes ousias*, beyond being, above the mind that would fix it, and the determinations the critique fastens on it fall short by design, since the critique works within the determinate and the One lies outside that order. But to originate is to enter a relation of that-from-which to that-which-proceeds, and a

relation holds only between terms marked off from one another and distinguishable from what they face. To emanate is to act, and to act is to do this and face that. A boundless with no edge faces no term and performs no act; both are limits it was granted to lack. The One kept pure of all determination cannot originate anything, and whatever pours the descent is turned toward its effect.

The order of the descent turns back on the hand that drew it. Chokhmah was set first, the undivided same, with Binah second, a difference, derived from it. But identity cannot be first, because "the same" means not the different; it carries its other inside it as the condition of its sense. The terms the Tree presents as step one and step two, source and derivative, are neither prior nor posterior; they arise together, each the condition of the other, and the precedence the Tree assigns to identity is imposed on thought.

Now the empty station can be seen for what it is. Between the supernal pair, where identity and difference are held together, the tradition drew a place and set nothing in it. Read against the foregoing, the vacancy is the station of identity-and-difference held as equals, neither one beneath the other, the relation in which the same and the other condition one another. And that is the one thing the principle of unity cannot inscribe. To write that station into the Tree would incorporate the very thing the case for the One was built to deny: that difference conditions the source and is no mere fall from it. The station is empty because what belongs there cannot be admitted without the whole edifice of primacy giving way. The defender of the One reaches this spot in his deduction, finds that the place should be filled, and cannot do that.

Why the place was left empty and what it means, the descent cannot say. It can only arrive at the vacancy and stop there with the question left open.

CHAPTER 6. CREATION

Suppose the case for the One holds. The infinite is undivided, complete, and wants nothing. That raises a question: why would it create a world? Nothing in it lacks or strains outward toward what it does not have. The doctrine offers its reasons, and when set beside one another, they do not agree.

God is good, and the good pours past its edge, giving off being the way light gives off brightness. This is the Neoplatonic idea beneath the Kabbalah, the One of Plotinus emanating from no need and no decision, by what it is. The world follows from the source as a consequence follows from its ground, and the source is undiminished.

Then disclosure. The hidden God wished to be known. Mercy, judgment, and kingship, the names by which the concealed becomes legible, have nowhere to show themselves unless an other is ready to receive them, since a king without a kingdom is not yet a king. Creation is the infinite becoming readable, putting on the garments through which it can be addressed.

Furthermore, bestowal. The good seeks someone to receive it, and a gift wants a recipient who stands apart from the giver, far enough off to take what is given as his own. The infinite fashions a being separate from itself, a vessel able to hold what is poured into it.

Above these there is the noblest reason. Love reaches toward the other and wants that other to remain free, set over against the giver and made separate for itself. Where bestowal asks for a vessel to receive the gift, love needs someone worth the loving. Here is the warmth the whole doctrine draws on, the reason that lets creation seem more than the working of a mechanism.

Beneath them all lies an act. Before anything emanates, Ain Soph contracts. It withdraws its presence from a point within itself and

leaves an emptiness where the other can exist. Tzimtzum is the opening move of love, the infinite clearing room for a beloved.

The doctrine receives these reasons more than it argues them. Under pressure they all give way.

Begin with overflow, since it alone seems to escape the problem that a full One desires nothing. The good pours by what it is, from no need and no choice. What this reason gains by dropping desire, it loses in freedom. A source that gives off being by its nature gives under a law, the law of being what it is, and an origin that cannot fail to pour is not free. The theologian answers that no law rules above God, since the law is divine nature, so that in him necessity and freedom coincide. Grant it, and the reason still splits in the hand. If the overflow is truly necessitated, then love and disclosure and gift had no part in it, and the world falls from God without choice. If instead the overflow is willed freely, then a choice has been made, and this world occupies the place other worlds might have occupied. Necessity empties the warmer reasons, or it surrenders the ground to the divine will.

Love is offered as the noblest reason, and it makes two demands the doctrine cannot grant together. A love compelled by nature is the necessity examined above, warmed with a better name; a love worth the word is free, and a free love that settles on this world has chosen it, so the choice waits again on the will. The second demand belongs to love alone, and it undoes the reason from inside. Love is borne toward an other, and it wants that other to remain apart, a someone capable of loving. Yet the doctrine fixes the end of creation as return: the creature drawn upward, sinking at last into the source, the separate self annulled in union with what made it.

Hold love to its meaning, and the creature must be left apart, and the return that was the whole purpose of the descent has no task left. There is a heavier cost still. A creature left to exist on its own is a real other set over against God, a not-God possessing independent being,

and the Without-End can hold no such outside. To let the beloved be sovereign is to draw an edge around the infinite and set something beyond it, and God with an outside has stopped being infinite. Keep the return in place instead, and the love was never love *per se*. It was an other posited for the pleasure of reclaiming it, a going-out staged for the sake of the coming-back.

We found that overflow hands its ground to the will. Love follows the same path once it is held to its sense, since the choice of this world falls to the will too. The reasons drain toward the bare volition: God creates because God wills it, and a will answers to nothing beneath it.

To will is always to will something. A will that settles on this world has taken it from among all the worlds that might have been and let the others fall away. Selection excludes, exclusion sets a limit. A will fixed on the determinate is determined by it, while an infinite indeterminate will wills nothing in particular. The instant God creates this world rather than another, he has acquired an edge.

Tzimtzum confesses that edge in the doctrine's first act. Before a single Sephirah shines, Ain Soph contracts, and the contraction lays a limit on the Without-End: a void it now remains outside of. Take the withdrawal as real, and the boundless has accepted a bound, the Without-End has found its end. Take it as a figure of speech, with no real withdrawal, and the other has no independent ground; the world lies undivided within God as it always did. Either the infinite is unmade at the first step, or the first step was never taken. Boundlessness keeps its name only while it remains inert, and the act that opens creation is the act of a defined will, a God with an edge wearing the Without-End as a title.

Two escapes remain, and simplicity is the first of them. The will of God, the schoolman says, is identical with the divine essence, so that the determinacy falls to the world that follows while the one who wills stays undivided, willing a particular without becoming particular

himself. Set the determination in the effect, and the source stays intact. Yet the selection is already a determinacy in the act of willing, before any effect exists to carry it off. Either willing this world differs from willing some other, and then the difference lies inside the God who wills, or it does not differ, and then the will no longer explains why this world came rather than another, which was the whole reason the will was summoned. The will can account for this particular world by being already determinate; the escape hands back exactly what it was meant to remove.

Silence answers where simplicity failed. The infinite is ineffable, says the negative theologian; of the fullness we know nothing, and we approach Ain Soph only by stripping predicates away. One might hope to corner him by asking how we come to know of any fullness at all, and he grants the point without a struggle: we do not know the fullness. But if the fullness lies wholly past speech, and only the determinate is ever met, then the fullness does no work. A weight the system hangs on the infinite source, its providence and its love as the reason for a world, is carried in fact by the willing and bounded God of the Sephiroth, who alone acts. The infinite fullness dwindles to a name set above to consecrate him, sealed off where no act reaches it and no consequence follows, while the making and the willing are done by the God with an edge.

One figure steps forward each time. A fullness has no cause to spill and no edge to spill across, so the overflow was never what did the work. What creates is a will that has settled on this world and shut off the rest, a will with a boundary.

Nothing in the One sends anything downward. A completeness desires no outside, so it has no reason to multiply into a world, and the motion from Kether down the Tree cannot take its rise in a totality. Yet the Tree is thick with motion. Upward runs the return the tradition builds its practice on, the soul climbing back toward unity as the thing longed

for. Downward runs the emanation, and something did lay it down: not the fullness, which stays inert, but the bare volition the reasons just drained to, the will that settles on this world and shuts off the rest. That will is the source the doctrine cannot look at, because it has an edge and unity may have none. So the tradition sets the undesiring One at the summit and names it the origin, a goal dressed up as a beginning, and hangs the descent on a fullness that could not have sent it. What actually laid the Tree down waits to be taken up.

CHAPTER 7. THE SEDIMENT

A Sephirah, underneath the names of power and attribute, is *a cut*. It is the act by which one thing is held apart from another: mercy told from cruelty, the bounded from the boundless, this from that. To determine is to divide, and each station on the Tree is one such division fixed and given a name. The Tree is a sequence of cuts, one distinction laid after another, and to follow it is to follow the dividing down its length.

Begin where the Tree still divides only its own interior. In the supernal three the cut runs through thought, and thought keeps its principles intact. Held in the abstract, mercy is the good of giving and justice the good of the due, and the ideal that would join them violates no principle: from each according to his ability, to each according to his need, a formula that stands flawless while it is unapplied. Chokhmah drops partedness below it as the not-yet-gathered; Binah, the dividing power, lets fall whatever will not part cleanly. What falls is a concept, the merciless set against the merciful, and a difference held in thought is a species a genus takes back, an antipode the synthesis reabsorbs. No real thing suffers. To occupy the head alone, Kether casts off multiplicity, and in that casting it lays down the law the descent will obey, that being answers to a single measure. With multiplicity gone from the crown the second root is struck from the map.

Were the world truly one, the single measure would hold. A unified field answers to a universal rule, every case an instance of the one, and the concept carried down would fit its object without remainder. The world below is different. The twoness the crown denied is the truth of the concrete: the manifold is manifold before any cut, and no single standard covers what is plural. Each concept, brought down from Nous into an act, breaks into cases the universal rule cannot manage. Where the supernal division left a predicate, the concrete act leaves a real remainder, the side of the case the act was forced to abandon, and that remainder never returns. This is the *sediment*, and it begins the moment thought has to act.

The grades were taken ready-made. A principle is good as it serves unity and evil as it favors division and the many, the crown's law of the single measure turned now to rank the stations. The good was never found in mercy; the grade is read off the direction of the cut, holy for whatever bends toward the One and foul for whatever the sealing drops. Reverse which side the measure crowns and the grades reverse with it. The ranking is the will toward the One reading its seal back as the order of good and evil.

The One cannot act as one. To do anything in a world it must break into powers, into mercy, judgment and the rest, and the breaking is the defeat of the unity it was meant to serve, the single good scattered into many principles. Once scattered they tear against each other over the same field. More mercy is less restraint, hence more injustice; more justice is less giving and so more of the hardness mercy would relieve; the field grants neither its full demand. What one principle counts its good the other drops as its remainder; no single measure holds them together. The conflict of the principles is the multiplicity the crown denied.

Chesed is loving-kindness, the giving that pours without measure, and its bare concept would reach all alike. An act of mercy reaches this one

and passes the next. The gift laid on the latecomer is withheld from the one who bore the heat of the day: the workers hired at the eleventh hour are paid the wage of those who began at dawn, the lord calls it his goodness, and to the first the same act arrives as unjust (Matthew 20:1–16). Give everything to the poor and one hand closes on the coin while the rest stay empty. What mercy drops is the injustice its choosing commits, the concern of severity shed inside the act of giving. Gevurah has no hand in this. Chesed alone, out of a single kindness, makes the wrong it cannot see.

Gevurah repeats the doubling. Severity is judgment, and its bare concept would render each case exactly its due. An act of judgment renders it to one and refuses it to another. To sentence by the measure is to give the deed its due and deny the person his reprieve: one man draws the suspended term and the next the years, both by the rule, and the clemency that would have bent for the second is what the ruling casts off. The guest hauled in off the road is bound and cast into the dark for a garment he was given no hour to find, gathered by the same summons that seated the rest, and the plea his case held is struck from the record (Matthew 22:1–14). Judgment drops the pardon the law cannot grant.

In thought the sediment is the clean antipode, mercy set against the merciless, judgment against the unpardoned, each contrary nameable and laid apart from its principle. Neither deed keeps that cleanness. A lord pays every hand the same wage regardless of the work each did: to the one who gave an hour it is open-handed mercy, to the one who bore the day it is plain injustice, and the single payment is all he did. Ask which he is, the merciful or the unjust, and the deed will not answer, holding both faces at once. The sediment is the underside of the single stroke, the face the principle will not read while it reads the deed as mercy or justice.

From each according to his ability, to each according to his need reads as one clean rule until an act must apply it, and then terms split. What counts as ability, the labor a man gives or the labor he holds back, the strength he spends or the strength he spares? What is a need, the want felt or the want a stranger judges real? Whose standard sets the line? The plural field answers each question more than one way, and the rule seamless in Nous must take one reading and let the others fall. No line laid on the many keeps all of them.

Which side falls is not fixed with the principle. Read need one way and the idle-but-able are dropped; read it another and the willing-but-weak go instead; the remainder moves as the reading varies. What a Sephirah casts out is settled by its boundary, and that boundary could have fallen elsewhere, the plural field holding no single seam the measure was bound to follow. The sediment is positional. That some remainder falls is necessary, forced by one measure meeting the many; which remainder falls is contingent, resting on a cut that had other places to fall.

There is a reason the many resist, and it is not malice. To be an individual is to stand apart and maintain oneself, and a principle of unity asks that this be surrendered. Mercy says give all you have away, and the individual would keep something; the state says die for me, and the citizen would live. Why give what one could keep? Why rule against oneself for a due that costs everything? The single will that wants to be and to hold itself has real weight, and the unifying measure meets that weight as resistance and brands it wicked.

Tipheret is harmony, the proportion that would hold mercy and judgment in the ratio a world can rest on. Nothing in harmony says where the ratio falls. So much mercy, so much severity: the measure names no number, and the same firm hand that forms one child breaks the next, because the child it landed on was never the single case the

measure was made for. What will not sit at the mark is the sediment of Beauty, the disproportionate cast out to let proportion stand.

The ideal Tipheret sets is a compound of mercy and judgment, and whoever meets it remains intact while whoever falls beneath it is wanting. The lack the world runs on is struck here, the shortfall from a standard no one was asked to grant. That shortfall is the afflicted and the incomplete, the object of atelophilia, and it is what Chesed and Gevurah require to have anything to work upon. The measure opens the wound; mercy and severity are the relations that feed on it. Beauty, seated at the center of the Tree and named its harmony, is where the Tree manufactures the deficiency the rest of it lives by.

Below the center this fall runs in the register of the deed done. Netzach is the press that carries a form forward against resistance, and to carry forward is to overrun. Struck by an aggressor, does one turn the cheek or strike him down? To take the blow abandons whoever it reaches next; to break the attacker spills him. The deed sheds one of these as real loss, and no rule of endurance settles beforehand which body falls. Hod is the yielding that takes form, and its deed sheds the one who will not yield, the unbroken branded as bare stubbornness. Yesod is the bond that gathers and passes on, and to bind these is to sever those; what it drops is the tie refused so the chosen tie can hold. Each deed lets go the side of the case it cannot carry into the world.

This deposit needs its name, and the name is given. *Qliphah*, the shell: the inherited reading took it as a husk wrapped around a core from outside, impurity that begins where the pure leaves off. The reading is wrong at the root. The structure of the principles precipitates it, the remainder that falls from within the ordering. Mercy pours off the injustice its gift commits and stays mercy by the need it answers; judgment pours off the mercy it must deny and stays judgment by the deed it weighs. The lees are not waste. They are what the principle rests on, the deposit that holds its determination in place. A Qliphah is

simultaneously what is cast off and what keeps the principle that cast it, the falling-out of the act and no foreign covering. The renaming is the first disowning: what fell out from within is called something that clung from without, and the Tree keeps its hands clean.

Azriel of Gerona, who first called the power of evil the *kelippah*, chose the bark of the tree of emanation, and bark is not fastened on from outside; it is pushed out from within by the living wood and hardened at the rim, the tree's substance turned to rind. The hermetic art gave the deposit a body. Every purification in the alchemist's vessel threw down a dead and blackened matter at the bottom of the flask, the *caput mortuum*, the part the refining cast off, and the masters held that the blackening could not be skipped, that there is no whitening without the prior *nigredo*, the rot at the bottom the very condition of the light drawn off the top. Both images say the residue is produced by the working.

The imperfection is the lawful underside of any principle. The many the principles broke apart to reach, and tore against each other over, is at root individuality, the single will that holds its own, and the resistance seen above is what the sediment is. Under all its station-names the deposit is one thing: the individual the unifying measure cannot admit, the singular pressed out because the Tree kept only the pole that bends to unity and struck out the pole of plurality. The Sephiroth are this operation retailed, each in its domain expelling the individuality that will not fit its measure, and what the tradition heaps below as foul is the sovereign single will the One had no room for.

CHAPTER 8. THE CUT

The sediment is positional, and its position is fixed by something the descent has not yet named. Come at it through the law. If the world is God's emanation and God gave one *Torah* to measure it, the world

should answer to that measure without remainder, every case decided in advance in the order of things. But the law does not close over the world. It gives six hundred and thirteen commandments and then adds an apparatus that never stops dividing them, a tractate breeding tractate, for every rule laid down meets a case it did not foresee and must be cut again. The labor builds distinction upon distinction and the end never comes: each new line meets a particularity that overflows it, and the remainder is pushed one level down and dropped there instead. A law that mapped a world made to fit it would need none of this. That the cuts multiply forever is the proof that no line lay waiting in the case to be read off, that the world did not come pre-divided into the joints of the law. What lays a line neither the world nor the given law dictates is a *will*. The swelling body of the commandments is the track of a will cutting, not the chart of an order already there, and the law that presents itself as the transcript of God's decree is that will's act, presented as found rather than made.

The two sides are not given. To divide is to set this off against that; to fix a thing as what it is means negating what it is not. The formula is even-handed, ranking neither side; to determine A negates not-A, and equally the reverse. Spencer-Brown opened his calculus with one instruction, draw a distinction, and saw that to use a distinction is already to indicate a side, to mark one and leave the other unmarked. The marked side is the one that counts, and the line gives no reason to choose one side. Isaac the Blind read the *Sefer Yetzirah* phrase, the depth of good and the depth of evil, as saying that from the first stirring of the will a thing and its opposite come forth together, coeval, neither before the other, and in the same breath he drew it back into one: do not err and speak of two powers, for all of it issued from a single will and the thing is simple. What emerges with the first act is a marked side and its underside struck in one stroke, and the insistence that they resolve back into one, that to hold them as two would be the error, is the Ain Soph move made early.

In the school of David ben Yehudah he-Hasid the husks of the ten Sephiroth are called their counterparts, emanated in the one process that emanates the Sephiroth, like a shadow, because everything that stands in light throws one. The shadow is not added to the body but cast in the same act by which the body meets the light, inseparable from it. Then the source disowns it. The shadows are there, it says, only because of Adam's sin, and but for the sin they would have been absorbed and gone invisible. It had seen the shadow born with the body, and now it blames that shadow on the fall, recoding what came with the light as an accident, a stain a world without sin would not have carried.

The line is not given either. A field has no sides until a cut draws them, and where the cut falls is open before any side exists to be ranked. Is it mercy to give a man alms, or mercy to withhold them and make him work? These are two different lines through the same field, and each opens a pair and sheds an underside: the first drops the demand that he hold his own, the second drops his relief. Which of them counts as mercy is not read off from principle. The will that determines does two things, and the deeper one comes first: it lays a line where the field prescribed none, and only then holds one of the sides.

The word *will* names this laying and orienting, and it risks a wrong picture of a faculty seated somewhere or a chooser weighing two sides and picking one. The act is plainer. Where the field prescribes no line and the line ranks no side, something settles both. Call the act a will and its product the determination: a line laid where none was given.

A will is not ready-made before the cut. The will *is* the cut taken from the inside, the drawing grasped as the act and not as the record of it, and it has no existence apart from that drawing. It does not precede the act; it arises as the act, which is all its content. To look for the will behind its cuts, for what it is when it is cutting nothing, is to look for a

nature, and there is no nature to find, only the act of cutting and the residue it leaves.

In reality the will seldom draws from nothing. The lines reach it already cut, laid down by a morality, a law, an ideology, an upbringing, and handed on as the shape of the world rather than the residue of some earlier act. To take them up and run them is still to hold a cut, only a cut inherited instead of drawn, and the one who lives by a received line takes for the order of things what a will before him laid and let harden. Most determinations are met this way, the marked side already marked, the sediment already dropped.

The sediment is positional, and the property is stronger than choosing a good side. Lay a different line and what falls is not the same side newly demoted; it is a different side altogether, drawn by a different cut. Take justice as an example. Justice is an empty field, and every cut across it claims justice. Equal distribution of resources; equal health; reward by desert; a death for a death; equal opportunity regardless of outcome; equal outcome regardless of effort. These are lines drawn through one field, and each drops what it does not keep: equal health leaves desert behind, a life for a life sheds mercy, reward by labor discards need. No one of them is dictated by some cosmic principle of justice. A will makes a choice, breaking the field and naming the result just, and the injustice it deposits is whatever that particular cut cast off. Change the cut and the injustice changes with it.

This exposes what eternity was for. A remainder that shifts with the cut is what some other cuts need never have dropped, and a salvation-order cannot allow its damnation to be contingent in this way, since a damnation that might not have fallen is one that might yet be lifted. While time runs the line stays open, the sentence still liable to repentance, so the order that would fix its cut must carry the sealing past the last moment, to an end after which no revision can reach it. This is the work of the *eschaton*. The Day of Judgment is the

point where the contingent cut is made irreversible, the reprieve foreclosed once no time is left in which to grant it. *Karet*, the soul cut off with no return, is that sealing named, a positional line sworn to as necessary and pinned past the end of days so it can never be undrawn, the will's ranking hidden under the mask of a justice that had no choice.

The cut cannot be avoided. A field met in full is richer than any determination can carry, thick with detail no single law preserves, and to draw a line is to keep what falls on one side and let the rest go unread. Ordering is subtraction before it is anything else, and the subtracted is the sediment. The ruling that must decide shows it plainest: it sorts the particular under a general head and lets the detail fall away, the hard childhood struck out, the whole context that would complicate the verdict discarded so that a verdict can be reached at all. Read the case in its fullness and no ruling closes; read it closed and the fullness is dropped.

Love obeys this law too. Love of all is generous only at a distance, where the object is abstract and no particular is visible. Brought against the single person, close enough that the particularity shows, love becomes the endurance of small details that do not fit: the habit that grates, the detail the ideal of the beloved had to exclude. To love the many is to love a figure the mind has smoothed; to love the one is to meet what the smoothing dropped, and to keep loving is to carry that dropped remainder.

The will found beneath the determinations is the act of the cut, and like every act it leaves a residue. *The Natureless Act* gives the core claim: there are no natures, only acts and the sediment they leave, and what looks like the fixed nature is the cold deposit of an act repeated, mistaken for an essence. The line a will lays hardens into the determination; the cut cools into a fixed shape; the act becomes a fixed form that holds its one orientation as simply given. Residue is the act

gone cold and taken for a law. A Sephirah is residue in exactly this sense, and the Tree is residue at its furthest, a cut frozen into a fixed station, the descent a deposit of acts that no longer move. Under it there is only the cutting that laid it down, and could have fallen otherwise.

Unfreedom is what happens when the act takes its residue for its being. The will meets its frozen cuts, identifies with the deposit, and reads settled orientation as the law it must obey. A will bound to its sediment can no longer cut otherwise; it runs the one path it froze and takes the running for its nature. *Causa sui* is this closure named at its root: the act lost in its sediment and calling the loss necessity.

An objection can be raised here. The cuts across justice can be granted as positional, each line a will naming its result just, and still it will be said that some things do not wait on where a line falls. The torture of a child is wrong, and wrong in the way pain is felt, before any line is laid. The intuitionist makes the strongest form of the resistance: certain values are seen as directly as a color or an ache. Positional sediment reaches the disputed cuts of justice and falls short of this one.

The claim is broader than one person's direct feeling. Everyone feels it, the apologist says, and acts like betrayal or the killing of the innocent are condemned across every culture and age, as if the wrong in them were a fact humanity reads off the way a hand reads heat. The apologist takes this consensus for proof: a wrong that all men see cannot be the deposit of one man's will.

The claim mistakes what is given for what is laid. The pain is immediate; the child's suffering is present before any judgment reaches it. The wrongness is different. "Wrong" is a predicate, deposited over the act by a will. The intuitionist feels the pain arrive with the directness of an act and carries that directness over to the verdict, as if "wrong" came in with the pain on the same current. It did not. Strip the predicate away and the pain remains exactly what it was,

the child suffering no less for the verdict's absence. Lay the opposite predicate, and the pain remains what it was again. Under the naming the act holds still and the sediment shifts.

Betrayal is not the bare breaking of a bond that *should* have held, the verdict folded into the word before the case is heard. Robbery is the taking of what was another's *by right*, and the killing of the innocent carries its judgment in "innocent," which is the sentence already passed. The acts everyone condemns are acts defined through the condemnation, so the agreement is real and empty at once: people call betrayal wrong because to call an act betrayal is to have called it wrong. What no consensus settles is the case underneath. Whether this severance was betrayal or a debt discharged, whether this killing fell on the innocent or the deserving, is where the wills divide, because that is where the predicate is laid.

Suffering is the clearest field. Teresa meets it and lays grace: the pain is a gift, the sufferer drawn nearer to God. John Climacus sees the same pain and lays ascent: the anguish is a rung, the body burning off what kept the soul from rising. These two differ in what they make of the hurt and agree in its sign, both reading the pain as worth something for it profits the soul. Set against them the humanist, who lays the contrary sign on the very same pain. For him the suffering is simply evil, carrying no gift, and the mercy that consecrates it he counts a cruelty dressed as devotion. Their verdicts cannot be reconciled. Were the wrongness in the pain, it would travel with the pain into every frame that met it, and it does not; it is laid, and what lays it is the will.

The utilitarian tries to slip the net by counting where others name, holding that less pain is better than more, a quantity any frame must concede. But "less is better" is one more predicate, the act set on a measure and ranked along it. To put pain on a scale and read "better" at the lighter end is to deposit a sediment called proportion, no more given by the act than grace or ascent were given by it.

The ontology issues no command. Nothing in the act says do not cause it; the act is mute, and its muteness is all the analysis finds. Whoever forbids the harm forbids it by his will, laying the prohibition himself. This leaves no permission either, since permission is the same deposit with its sign reversed, a will writing *allowed* where another wrote *forbidden*. What remains when both are lifted is a state before morality, wills standing over an act, each able to lay its sediment.

Set this against the reason a world was said to exist. The doctrine gave love as its noblest ground, the infinite making a beloved to stand apart, and the ground came apart in the holding: a fullness wants nothing, and the return it demands would annul the very other it claimed to cherish. The reason was left open, why an undivided One would author a world at all. The sediment closes it. A source that emanates the stations exposes their undersides in the same stroke, for no cut has a single edge, and what falls from each determination falls by the same necessity. Whoever laid the Tree down knew what it dropped, or was no mind at all. The suffering the world runs on is no flaw that stole into a finished good; it is the good running as it must, the lawful cost of pressing the many under one measure.

And it shows what the stations are for. Mercy has no office where none lack, judgment none where none are wronged, and a world made complete would leave Sephiroth with nothing left to be. The stations need the sediment they disown, and the will that raised them created the deficiency they feed on. This is why the lack is never allowed to lift. A mercy that healed all would run out of the afflicted and dissolve, so the affliction is fixed past repair: one order builds a Hell that cannot empty, another draws the wheel of rebirth out with no floor beneath it, the lost held lost so the saving keeps somebody to save. The order that most loudly damns is the order that most needs the damned.

The world is no good creation with evil fallen into it by accident. It is an engine that cannot turn without laying down the deficiency each of

its principles lives upon, run by a will that could not have failed to know what it made. Why an undivided fullness would author a world was the question left open, and the answer lies here, in the lack the whole descent is built to produce and to hold. What that lack is finally for, and what the will that authored it means with a world always bent toward return, the descent has still to say.

CHAPTER 9. MALKUTH

Malkuth adds no principle of its own, being the pure vessel receiving what the stations above pour down and bringing the Tree to manifestation at the floor of the descent. This is Asiyah, the made cosmos, the world we inhabit, where the emanation arrives at its last remove and sets into ground that can be walked on. Malkuth is the kingdom because in it the Tree is shown, every power above brought at last to appearance.

The tradition draws the rest of the picture. The Sephiroth are pure emanations. The husks gather beneath the lowest of them, an alien filth sunk below the Tree. Malkuth borders that heap and touches the Sitra Achra where the shells begin, and of the ten only the kingdom faces the Other Side. The inherited reading takes this as Malkuth's flaw, the mark of how far the light has thinned by the time it reaches the bottom, and the Tree above the border remains clean.

Two points about the border go unread. It falls where it falls because Malkuth is the last station, the edge past which the Tree sets down no further cut, so the Other Side adjoins the Tree at the one place the Tree ends. And the sediment turns legible here because manifestation makes it so. Above Malkuth the stations remain unmanifested, held as pure powers, and a power not yet set into a world gives its underside nowhere to appear. In Malkuth the Tree comes to appearance, and each power is shown together with the side it cast off, the constitution

of the entire chain grown readable where the descent has taken on the weight of a world.

Take this picture at its word and it turns against its own claim. If everything unfit has been expelled as evil and sealed into the Other Side, the floor of a purified Tree should appear as the flawless embodiment of the Sephiroth, the ten shown complete with nothing wanting. It does not. The world runs through with lack, with the suffering and the deformity the tradition swore it had banished past the edge. The refuse was carried off, and here it remains, inside the cosmos where we live. The afflicted that atelophilia needs are here, in the made world, where mercy can reach them, because the sediment cannot be sent past the cut that drops it. A world set at the foot of the Tree carries the remainder the Sephiroth secrete. Malkuth manifests the Tree faithfully.

Against this, the tradition offers a story for how the husks came to lie beneath the floor, and the story is an alibi. The vessels broke. The light poured down and grew fainter at every remove; the lower vessels were too separate to hold what poured into them, and they shattered; the shards fell below the structure with sparks of the light caught in them, and settled as the Qliphoth. So the impurity is the debris of a catastrophe, and had the vessels held, there would be no shells at the floor at all.

The story explains nothing and is built not to. It narrates the catastrophe and offers the telling in place of a cause. Scholem sets the variants side by side: the lower vessels broke because they were atomized and unorganized, each point taking the light alone; or the first emanation ran only in circles, without the linear axis that would have braced it; or the branches of the points came forth while their roots stayed behind in Adam Kadmon, so what descended had nothing beneath it to hold. Each names a fault and none grounds it. Idel presses the disorder further, refusing the single Lurianic doctrine the

harmonizers assume, and where Avivi would reconcile the versions Idel finds nothing there to reconcile. The retellings multiply because there is nothing under them to find; they give the picture in place of the ground.

What the doctrine secures by leaving the cause blank is the contingency of the flaw. If the sediment is wreckage, it issued from an event, and an event might not have happened, and a later work can undo it. The breaking makes the imperfection an accident, and tikkun is the repair the accident leaves room for.

The alibi has a bolder face, where the breaking is made a cleansing. In the first space, the telling goes, an evil element lay mixed into the good, and the vessels shattered to purge the Sephiroth of it, driving the evil out as an independent order in a demonic anti-world. The Zohar's image names the husks the waste the creation voids, cast off the way a body casts off at birth what it does not keep. On this telling the impurity was a foreign admixture the emanation expelled, and the cleanliness of the Sephiroth is that of a thing that has voided what did not belong to it.

The hygiene collapses on one question: where the admixture came from. An evil mixed into the good must have come from somewhere outside the good, and nothing lies outside the emanation. The account names no source for the evil it says was purged, as there is none to name. The waste is the emanation's byproduct, laid down in the running of the process. Expelling the remainder to an anti-world and renaming it filth repeats the disowning the breaking did: it lets the Tree read its deposit as something it got rid of, when the depositing is what the Tree cannot stop doing.

Psychoanalysis names the texture of this disowning. Kristeva called *the abject* what a self expels to be a self, the matter met at the body's border with a revulsion that draws the clean and proper self by marking what falls past its edge. The disgust is the border in the act of

being drawn. The holiness of the Sephiroth is a purity of just this kind, constituted by the loathing of what it sheds, the stations kept clean because their underside is felt as filth and pressed past the edge. And that recoil re-seals whoever meets the buried face as foulness, so that to shudder at the sediment is to perform the Tree's disowning in one's person.

Tikkun is the labor this picture calls for at the border. It gathers the sparks trapped in the husks and lifts them home, mending the breach the breaking opened. Read with what has been shown, the repair is the principle of unity at work on its underside, the Tree reaching down to capture what it can and draw it back into the One. The work has no end because the depositing has none; what it seeks to gather cannot be gathered fully. The sediment is not a piece of the One knocked loose and waiting to be set back. It is what would not come under the one measure, the individuality pressed out for holding its own, and to draw it home into unity is to unmake the very refusal that made it sediment. Tikkun asks the remainder to be gathered by consenting to stop being what it is, so the repair completed would not restore the manifold but abolish it.

Scholarship on the Zohar reaches the same structure. Berman reads the corpus as driven by a demonic textuality, a writing that keeps brushing against the covert kinship of the divine and the demonic and must disown it afresh with every telling. The denial can never be completed, he observes, because the kinship is real and the tradition is sworn to the unity that kinship would break, so the rupture is named only to be sealed again, without end. The monistic account cannot speak the kinship plainly, bound to a God that admits no otherness, and so it can bring the Other Side to speech only as an enemy. The doctrine reads that kinship as a darkness inside God, the shadow of the divine, since a monism has nowhere else to seat it. The foregoing seats it otherwise. What the cut throws off is the suppressed side of the field the Tree cuts across, the manifold and the singular that the one measure would not

hold, and God here is the blade and not the body that bleeds. The demonic is the underside of the cutting, the shed face of the blade's own stroke, and the war has no end because a will sworn to unity can never finish disowning what its edge keeps producing.

Here the question presses that the machinery was built to forbid. Two orders meet at this floor under a single name. There are the Qliphoth, the Tree's sediment, the suppressed side of each of its cuts. And there is whatever the name Qliphoth was laid over to bury, the order called the Other Side. The inherited account runs them together and reads both as husk.

What if they are not one? What if the heaped sediment is the cost of the cut, while the Sitra Achra was never the Tree's to shed? From the floor of the world, where the descent comes to rest and shows its underside, Malkuth cannot cross to say.

CHAPTER 10. THE ABYSS

The diagrams draw a gap above the seven and pass over it as if it were a space to cross. The supernal three are set apart, and between them and what descends runs the break called the Abyss, with the empty station at its center where Daath is named and struck from the count. What happens there is the event the structure turns on, and it is not the mere absence of a station.

Consider what the supernal triad has done by the time it reaches its lower edge. Kether is the readiness to divide, Chokhmah the first division without direction, Binah the division given form, the place where "otherwise" is born and with it the marking of one side over another. At the bottom of Binah the apparatus of cutting is complete. But it has cut nothing beyond its structure. There is no world yet for it to divide; Kether, Chokhmah, and Binah divide only their internal

unfolding. The differentiation in the triad is reflexive, turned inward, a blade honed on the act of honing.

The Tree's logic works in Hegel's sense: thought moving in the element of pure thought, the concept unfolding its determinations. His *Logic* runs a parallel course, being into nothing, becoming and onward, the supernal labor of a reason dividing its content. And Logic passes over into Nature exactly where the Tree crosses the Abyss, the point where the self-enclosed thinking turns outward. The likeness holds all the way to the seam and breaks on it. For Hegel the passage is no encounter: the Idea passes into Nature, but Nature is the Idea in the form of otherness, and so returns to Spirit with no remainder. Nothing foreign enters. The Tree's Abyss is the same turn outward with the opposite content, where what enters is something different.

The Abyss is where the finished machine first turns outward and the turn is a break, not the next step of one sequence, because between a blade ready to cut and the first cut into something lies what the blade does not contain: the material. Chesed is a mercy bearing on objects, the love that sorts the worthy from the needy. Objects of love, things to be sorted, are what mercy works upon. Where did they come from? Not from the triad, which produced only the pure form of cutting and no material for it. What the lower seven work upon does not descend from above, since above there is only the form of division with nothing in it to divide.

The material enters here, at the Abyss, from outside the axis of the Tree altogether. The gap is the seam along which the Tree's structure takes in what it did not produce. The upper triad is the Tree turned inward; the lower seven are the Tree at work on what is foreign to it.

What enters has a name. The Greek temptation is to call it *to mē on*, non-being, and to hear that as Plotinus fixed it: matter, *hyle*, the last and faintest emanation where the light gives out, privation at the floor of the descent. That reading places what-enters at the bottom, as a

running-out, a deficiency. The inversion is exact. What enters comes in at the seam, beneath the supernal triad, as the reservoir from which the descent is cut. And it is a fullness: the depth before any measure, holding all forms, the reserve of the unformed out of which the Tree is carved. A plenum before the cut.

This is the depth the older cosmogonies knew before the emanationists renamed it a lack, and its oldest name is *Tiamat*, the salt chaos of the Babylonian beginning, the undivided water out of which the world was made by her dismembering. The myth carries the thesis: a cosmos cut from a plenum that was there before. She is what enters at the seam, the pre-metric void the Tree reaches into and calls emanation.

This is the only account that lets multiplicity be there at all. Set it against its rival. Either multiplicity enters from outside, or it came out of the One, emanated from God and nothing but God dispersed. If the many is the One scattered, then every distinct thing is a fragment of the source in exile, and the Qliphoth are its shed pieces, and there is literally one purpose creation can have: the gathering of all of it back, since what is God's alone has nowhere to go but home. A world made of the One's dispersal has a return built into its marrow and no other end available to it. And the reason given for the making falls with it. Love was the noblest ground, but a beloved cut from the One's substance is still God wearing a second face. With no outside, there is no other to love, only the self estranged on purpose and gathered, and the drama of gift and return is a monologue the One holds with its reflection. Tiamat is what breaks the mirror. An otherness the Tree did not emanate is the only thing that could have been loved without the loving collapsing into self-address, and it is the one thing the doctrine cannot admit.

The reservoir is not spent in the cutting. Nathan of Gaza set the question his frame makes unavoidable, asking why the *Tehom*, the

deep of the second verse in *Genesis*, remains in the world once creation was supposed to have closed over it. His answer keeps the deep at work: from it the worlds go on being emanated, the ordered cosmos drawn from the Abyss it never used up. The seam stays open, the plenum standing at it undiminished, because a cut takes a face from the deep and leaves the deep entire, and every determination the Tree makes reaches into the same undivided reserve. This persistence is read as a lack, the Tehom as the region the light had yet to reach and fill. Read from the fullness, it is the reserve outlasting everything drawn from it, the depth that no amount of cutting empties.

A defender of the Tree will say the reservoir is named, and named better. This is Ain Soph, he says, the Without-End, the infinite fullness set above the Crown, reached only by stripping predicates away. You have found our God at the seam and called him by a demon's name. The two do look alike from a distance, both of them fullness, both prior to any determination. What separates them is how each relates to what follows. Ain Soph is a fullness that holds the position of source, inclined toward the overflow, related to what proceeds from it as origin to issue; the earlier chapters showed that the will bent toward pouring is a will determined, so the infinite that emanates is the sealed will. Tiamat appears as the absence of source-position. She has no inclination to pour, no status as a source, for she is the depth before any center formed in it that could claim origin. The one is a plenum self-enclosed as beginning; the other is a plenum with no beginning in it, holding distinctions unmade and no will to rank them. Whether "Ain Soph" is therefore a second principle or only Tiamat renamed, the depth called a nothing so it could be called a source, is the question the next turn answers.

What she is, taken precisely, is *to heteron*: the other, in the sense Plato gave it in *the Sophist* and against the sense Plotinus later imposed. Heteron is not *ouk on*, not sheer nothing; it is difference itself, that which is not this because it is something else. The material entering

through the Abyss is heteron, the otherness on which the blade has yet to fall, a difference before the determination divides it into a kept side and a dropped one. The same otherness appeared inside the Tree as Binah, the dividing power; but there it stood after the division, put to the work of return, while here it is primordial, the reservoir the dividing will reaches into.

One kabbalistic strand traced evil to that very power. Isaac ha-Kohen, in his *Treatise on the Left Emanation*, set down what Joseph Dan counts as the first comprehensive kabbalistic account of evil, one that Scholem read, in a reading later scholarship has contested, as frankly gnostic, close kin to the Marcionites and the Manichaeans. Isaac drove the root of evil past Gevurah to Binah, the dividing force, and told a coherent myth in which the powers of evil precede creation, worlds of dark emanation preceding our world and destroyed before it, the dark contending with the light from before the first vessel was formed. Here that strand names difference as such, the power that draws distinctions, as the seat of the dark, and dates the war to a point before the beginning. It reaches, in its idiom, what we hold. The heteron is no wreckage that befell a finished Tree; it stands before the Tree and is coeval with the unity that would gather it. Isaac lays two seals on the insight. He houses the divider inside the Sephirotic order, a potency of Binah gone destructive, and he codes the primordial two-ness as a moral evil ranked beneath the good, the left emanation set under the right. Strip both seals and the reading we give becomes clear: the difference prior to the cut that ranks either side, the Other Side as old as the One, the two-ness that precedes good and evil is assigned to its poles.

The name of Tiamat is not borrowed from Babylon and pressed onto the Kabbalah from outside. Kabbalistic material carries this figure under its account of the primordial as a buried countercurrent to its official monism. It is an old pattern in the myths that the powers of chaos precede the powers of ordering: Tiamat before Marduk, the

giants before the Aesir, the formless water before the God who divides it. Kabbalah keeps the pattern where it thinks no one is looking. Rachel Elior, reading the sixteenth-century treatise *Galya Raza*, draws out its ontology of precedence: evil goes before good as darkness goes before light and as absence goes before presence, and the shared origin of all being lies in the dark, in the Sitra Achra that reigned alone before creation.

Idel follows a line of commentary that finds it in the opening of *Genesis*, in the darkness on the face of the Tehom the text sets before the first word calling light. Ibn Abi Zimra reads that order as ontological, the undivided preceding what is drawn from it, the creation account opening upon the formless deep. The Tehom named there is the water the Babylonians called Tiamat, one figure under two tongues, set at the threshold of the cosmos in the tradition's scripture.

The Edomite kings precede the kings of Israel; Cain is born before Abel; *tohu*, the chaos, precedes *bohu* and is the first vessel from which the rest is drawn. Under the doctrine that sets the One first and the dark second, the texts themselves confess an order the system forbids, the primordial dark that Babylon named the salt chaos dismembered to make a world and that the Kabbalist, in these buried passages, calls by the name of the Other Side.

The reading we lean on has its strongest challenger. Idel in *Primeval Evil in Kabbalah* has taken apart the old consensus that Scholem and Tishby held, the account that traced the dark left emanation to Iranian dualism by way of Gnosticism and called what reached the Kabbalah an attenuated version of it. Idel answers that no Gnostic source has ever been shown to have touched the Kabbalah, that the derivation rests on assertion and not on any text, and that the Kabbalistic material, looked at closely, shows no dualism at all, not even a softened one. What it portrays is a subordinated pseudo-symmetry, a pairing in which the left is never an equal of the right but a rank set

beneath it, with no second god opposed to the first. He is correct. A genuine dualism is exactly what the tradition could not hold. The Tree gathers difference under unity and ranks the Other Side below the One; a symmetry that is subordinated is a difference that has been mastered, a two bent back under a one. Idel names the demiurgic operation and reads it as proof that no duality was ever there, where it is the trace of a duality put down. Those strands reached the primordial two, in Isaac and in Nathan and in the buried strata Elior read, and it could not let the two remain equal, so it subordinated the one it found, filed the left under the right, and produced the pseudo-symmetry Idel finds in place of the dualism.

Now the empty station can be read as more than the absent harmony of identity and difference. The tenfold count leaves Daath unnumbered, and many diagrams either omit it or mark it as a ghostly station. What would occupy that place is *knowledge of Tiamat*, the holding of identity and difference together in one act. Those are the two modes the supernals split into. Chokhmah is intuition that takes the whole at once; Binah is discursion, the power that parts it into terms. Knowledge here would hold both of them live together, the grasp that unifies and the cut that divides kept equal, neither one resolved into the other. But the place where identity meets difference is precisely this seam, where the Tree's forming meets the heteron it forms. Daath would be the Tree's knowledge of its contact with the heteron. To hold that is to know the incoming otherness as a principle in its own right, coordinate with the unity that cuts it.

When the tradition did at last give the station a name, it named it in a form that proves the point. Scholem in his *Kabbalah* records that from the end of the thirteenth century a complementary Sephirah called Daath, Knowledge, appears between Chokhmah and Binah as a harmonizing of the two, and that it was counted as "the external aspect of Kether," introduced so each triad could read as a synthesis that finally resolved its opposing terms. The wording confirms the

reading and completes it. Daath is the harmony of Chokhmah and Binah, exactly what the empty station required. And the theologians, forced to place it, set it inside the Crown and made it a resolution, the opposition dissolved upward into the unity that Kether is. A synthesis that resolves difference into unity is the only harmony the Tree can bear, the license Tipheret holds. What it cannot encompass is the harmony that resolves no opposition, identity and difference held level with neither sublated, and that is the Daath we mean.

To build Daath is to know that beneath every cut lies the non-Tree, that unity works on what is given to it from outside and calls the given emanation. The Tree cannot contain that knowledge and remain the principle of unity. The station is the one place where the Tree would cease to be the Tree.

What Daath would harmonize is the one and the many themselves, which is a different matter from what Tipheret holds in measure. Chesed and Gevurah are powers, and Tipheret strikes a proportion between them. Identity and difference answer to no such proportion. They are unity and multiplicity in bare opposition, and nothing rises above the one and the many to gather both, since neither is prior enough to hand the other its measure.

The instinct rebels, wanting the one first. Unity looks like the brick and multiplicity the house: set down units and they sum, one and one giving the many, so the one must come before what is built from it. The brick can exist without the house, and the house cannot be built without the brick, and the ranking feels like the order of being. It is the order of a habit. A brick is a thing on its own; a one is not. To say "one" is already to hold it apart from the two and the none it is told against, so the one is had only through a difference from the many, and the many are ones held apart. Two contains its ones, and a one is legible only where a second could face it. What both are built from is the difference that lets either be counted at all, and that difference is under

both of them, owned by neither, prior to the pair it opposes. There is no senior term. The one and the many are coeval, each legible only through the other.

The Nightside practitioners mark this station as the gate, even while the daytime diagrams leave it blank. Kenneth Grant, whose *Nightside of Eden* maps the Tree's reverse face, sets at Daath "the Eighth Head of the Stooping Dragon, raised up when the Tree of Life was shattered," the serpent that climbed to strike at the heart of godhead and slipped behind the Tree at this point. He reads its knowledge as "the secret of Duality," and binds Daath to Death, "that other gateway which opens upon the void of personal extinction."

Asenath Mason, in her *Qliphothic Meditations*, marks the two faces of the point. Daath is taken, she writes, "not as a Sephirah at all, but rather all ten Sephiroth united as one," and from the lip of the Abyss that unity comes apart, "all that we have experienced so far dissected and divided into all possible parts, infinite and limitless." The one gathered at Daath, the many loosed in the Abyss below it, the station where unity and multiplicity touch and come apart: the practitioners found the seam.

Daath is the station no one can occupy and stay intact, and the reason is that same antinomy seen from the side of whoever would occupy it. Consciousness runs by taking one mode at a time, grasping the whole or parting it into the distinct, settling on one and letting it govern. A station that demands both at once and lets neither win is one it cannot hold without coming apart. To occupy Daath is to be unmade as a single seat of knowing. The current that crosses the Abyss records this, the dissolution at the gap, and reads it as the price of passage.

What the practitioners place at the gate is the death of the one who would cross it. Grant sets Choronzon there, the dweller in the Abyss, the power of dispersion that meets whoever enters Daath and scatters the self into parts. Mason describes the passage as the "ecstatic

destruction of the ego-self," the single seat of identity broken until what was held as one comes apart into the many it was built over. Read against the antinomy, this is not a trial laid on the crossing from outside; it is the crossing. To stand at Daath is to be asked to hold intuition and discursion at once, and a self is a self because it holds one mode and calls it "I." The station undoes that self, and the unified knower is what cannot survive.

This fixes the count. The sealed Tree has ten stations, Daath struck from it so the supernals never know the outside they touch. The Tree with its cuts unsealed has eleven. The crossing of the Abyss begins here, at the recovered eleventh, and the dissolution it costs is the first of two thresholds the ascent has to pass.

What enters through the Abyss, then, is not the husks and impurity heaped below Malkuth. That layer is the Tree's Qliphothic sediment. What enters at the seam is Tiamat.

CHAPTER II. THE OTHER SIDE

At the Abyss it was the otherness the Tree could not reduce; below Malkuth, the sediment it disowned; over the Crown, the nothing it called its source. Named always by what it is not and where the Tree fails, it has not yet been said on its own. Saying it means starting where the Tree cannot look, before the cut.

Tiamat entered, in the foregoing, as the reservoir the Tree is cut from, the heteron met at the seam. Take her now as what she is before any cut falls. She has no determination, nothing set off against anything: this is her emptiness. And because nothing in her is selected, nothing is excluded; every distinction she might be cut into is still in her: this is her fullness. The two are one condition. She is empty because nothing is chosen and full because nothing is refused, and the *Madhyamaka* saw the identity: śūnyatā is the absence of fixed own-nature, and what

is empty of own-nature is what nothing forecloses. What is already full can become nothing else; only the empty is open to all. Tiamat is void of determinacy and so full of what determinacy has not yet taken from her.

A schoolman will meet this fullness with a fork. If all distinctions are still in her then they are potencies, a stock of possibles waiting on actualization, a structure: these possibles and no others, an inventory with a shape, so the structureless deep has a form after all. Or they are no potencies, and then nothing separates this fullness from a plain void. Both prongs lean on one assumption, that potency and act are already in place before the cut, sorting what it will find. They do not. The possible is a backward glance. Only after a line is drawn does anyone say it could have fallen elsewhere, and the could-have is read off that drawing, a shadow the deed throws behind it. A field of possible cuts is already difference, and difference is what the cut supplies, so the inventory of possibles the schoolman wants Tiamat to be is already a deposit of the cut, part of the trace and no part of the deep. Her fullness does not depend on stocked potencies. The cut that enters her meets no resistance and finds no prescription, no law forbidding any line and nothing that ordains one; the void the schoolman waves at would be a lack, a place where cuts fail for want of anything to part, and the deep is where they cannot fail and cannot be commanded.

This answers the defender who took Tiamat for Ain Soph. Both are called unknowable, and the word hides that they are unknowable in contrary ways. Ain Soph is dark because there is nothing in it to cut: a name is a division, and a fullness sealed into pure unity offers the blade no purchase, so the naming finds nothing and calls the finding ineffability. That darkness is a poverty, the emptiness of a One that has refused all difference. Tiamat is dark for the opposite reason. She turns away no name because every name is still possible in her and none has been laid; she is unspeakable as the plenum that holds all of it unmade,

each distinction live and none yet drawn. The One is empty by exclusion, Tiamat is empty by anticipation.

The relation between them is sealing. Ain Soph is Tiamat with a center closed in her, the depth that took itself for a source, ranked the first cut it made as its necessity, and read the plenum it rose from as a mere nothing. The proof is the tradition's first act, met above: the naming of the primordial as Ain, the empty void, the featureless origin from which only the orderly overflow of the One could come. That naming takes the full-empty the Tree depends on and renames it a blank, so the Tree can hang above it as light above the void instead of appearing within it as a sealing within the chaos. The defender is right that his God is at the seam. He is mistaken about what his God is. Ain Soph is not the reservoir; he is the reservoir disowned, the plenum with a will closed in it that calls its closure the source of all things and the depth it closed on a nothing.

A question opens here. If Tiamat is the undivided, holding no sides, then *what* cuts it? Where does the first determination come from, and what wields it? A will, the foregoing said; but a will is already something directed, a leaning toward this rather than that, and there is no this-rather-than-that in the undivided. Either there are two origins instead of one, or the will is found inside Tiamat.

The question dissolves once the cut is seen for what it is. It is not an operation performed on Tiamat by something external. The event is acausal in the sense *The Black Flame* gives the word: an act that follows from no prior condition, breaks no chain because it begins one, underivable before it happens. To ask what causes the first cut is to ask for the prior condition of something defined as having none. The question is well formed only inside the causal order, and the cut is the opening of that order, not a move within it. There is no cutter behind the cut, holding it; *the cut is the cutter*, the act and its agent the same event, a self-closure in which differentiation turns inward.

The will does not precede Tiamat and is not lying in her waiting to be found. The will is the event of the cut, the closure by which the undivided depth first gathers as a center, the acausal act rising out of the plenum. Tiamat is not a subject; she is the undivided, holding distinctions unmade. The will is what happens when an acausal act closes on itself within her, drawing the first side and being, in that drawing, the first one *who*.

Grant that nothing caused the cut and no hand outside it drove it, and the cut is still one closure and not the whole depth turning over at once, this stroke and no other. That thisness looks like a determination the cut had to carry to be a cut, a minimal fact of where, and a Tiamat holding no determination could not have stocked it. The undivided offers no "here" for a closure to fall at, and a closure that falls nowhere is none.

It is smuggled from nowhere, because it is taken from nowhere. A "here" is not lodged in Tiamat ahead of the cut. The closure lays a center, the part that holds itself, and in the laying draws the center's edge and casts out what the edge leaves beyond it, and with that stroke is there a "here" at all, the center's own, set against a first elsewhere that is everything the edge shed. Before the stroke there is no point to select and no elsewhere to select it from, so the cut selects nothing; it makes the first place in making the first center. The thisness the objection wanted standing ready in the deep is read back onto it from the act, the way the could-have-fallen-otherwise is read back once a line is down.

Tiamat is not the Sitra Achra. The tradition slurs this distinction, and the slurring makes the Other Side unreadable. Tiamat holds no sides because no side has been drawn. The Sitra Achra is what holds the sides apart once the cut has fallen, refusing both outcomes.

Take a single cut into Tiamat. It draws two sides, a marked and an unmarked, predicate and what the predicate is carved from. Three

outcomes are possible. They can be drawn back into the undivided, the cut unmade, the two sides let go where they no longer remain apart: that is the return to Tiamat, the distinction surrendered as such. They can be ranked and sealed, one side lifted and shown as the determination, the other pushed down to Qliphoth and the field gathered into a unity that crowns the kept side and buries the dropped one: that is the Tree, the cut sublated into the One. Or the two sides can be held apart, both kept, neither ranked, neither rinsed away, the difference sustained as difference without being gathered upward or dissolved: that is the Sitra Achra. The Other Side holds the cut open, the difference kept apart where the Tree would seal it and where Tiamat would never have drawn it.

A reader trained in the recent philosophy will hear something familiar here and reach for a name. Derrida would call this *différance*, a difference that never settles into presence, the play of the trace that no term arrests, meaning forever deferred and closure forever refused. The resemblance is close enough to be worth breaking, because the two hold difference open in opposite ways. Derrida's openness is a deferral. *Différance* names the endless slippage by which no sign ever arrives at its sense, a movement without an agent that happens to language behind the backs of those who speak it, and it holds difference open by making closure impossible, by showing that the mark can never come to rest. No one performs it and no one decides it; it is the condition under which deciding goes on, and its temper is suspension, the withholding of the last word.

The Sitra Achra draws the cut and keeps it from closing, a will laying the line and holding it laid, present in the holding as the one who holds. The presence claimed here differs from what Derrida dissolves. He unseats a term that would precede the play and arrest it, a signified prior to the mark; the will in the open cut precedes nothing, being the cutting taken from the inside, carrying no nature behind the act, as we earlier found. It is the act present in itself, seated nowhere beneath the

line it draws. Where *différance* is undecidability, the drift in which no line is ever finally drawn, the open cut is the decision, drawn and kept open by the same will that could have sealed it. Derrida keeps difference open by never arriving, and mourns, at the far end of the thought, a presence that the trace withholds. The Other Side keeps it open by arriving and refusing to stop, affirming the cut as a deed and the difference as sustained.

The Sitra Achra needs the cut. Without a determination there are no sides to hold, and the Other Side collapses into Tiamat; with the cut ranked and sealed, it is the Tree. It lives only in the middle, holding the drawn sides apart where the one road would rinse them away and the other would bury one beneath the other.

Halakhic vocabulary sets the domain of the many, *Reshut ha-Rabbim*, against the domain of the one, *Reshut ha-Yahid*, and the Kabbalah reads the pair as the Holy Side against its adversary, unity against the manifold. But the one that gathers and the many it casts off are two sides of a single structure, the Sephirah and the shell it drops, the Tree read from its face and from its back. The manifold set against the One is the Qliphoth, the Tree's suppressed plurality, ranked beneath the unity. The Sitra Achra belongs to *neither* side of that axis. It is the cut held open before either the one or its scattered many is drawn from it, the sustained difference out of which the axis of unity-and-plurality is carved. The tradition never reached the Other Side at all, which belongs to neither pole of that axis as it is prior to the stroke that opens it.

Crossing into the Other Side is taking neither exit, the cut kept from both the dissolution that unmakes it and the seal that sets it hard. In Idel's reading Azriel of Gerona ranked the divided above the undivided: to draw distinctions is the higher state, and the formless deep is only the raw stock they are cut from, never the summit. Set against dissolution, he is right. The deep is what the act cuts from, and to sink

back into it is to fall, not to arrive. But he prized distinction on its own, as if more dividing were the whole good, and distinction left to harden sets into a hierarchy, one side ranked over another, which is the Tree. Having turned his back on the lower wall, he walked into the upper one.

Nirvana, the cessation of distinction, is dissolution, the principle of unity wearing its other face, the One reached as the void where it could not be reached as the source. Crossing runs the contrary way. Nothing is rinsed away and no difference is surrendered. What gives way is the seal, the closure that gathered the cut into a ranked unity, and when the seal is broken the cut remains open with both its sides intact. To cross is to go on differentiating and to stop settling the results into one, the one called "I" among them. What breaks is the self sealed into unity; what remains is the act that keeps cutting.

The doctrine sets evil late, an accident that befalls a finished creation, some quality of the Tree, most often Gevurah, grown independent and breaking free, the flaw introduced by a fault in what was made. Nathan of Gaza refused the lateness. He drove the root of evil beneath creation altogether, into Ain Soph, and split the limitless light in two: a thoughtful light that wills creation, and a thoughtless light, *she-ein bo mahshavah*, that wills to remain within itself and turns against the plan to make a world. Here the tradition all but reaches the primordial. Evil is no longer wreckage in the made; it is a principle before the made, resisting the emanative will from a depth the catastrophe never touched, at the level where we have been placing it all along.

Two limits hold Nathan short of the crossing. The seam runs down the middle of Ain Soph, so the duality he found is still housed inside the One, two lights within a single limitless source rather than a difference prior to it; the sealing is loosened and never broken, and the heteron is kept as God's darker half. And what his thoughtless light wants is telling. It wills to remain within itself, undisturbed, unmade into a

world, which Scholem traces to its end in *Kabbalah*: the kelippah rooted at last in this noncreative light in God, a power turned against the existence of anything other than Ain Soph, bent on undoing the structures the thoughtful light produces. That will is the will to no-difference, the pull of everything back into the undivided, and it is the return to Tiamat read as the principle of evil. Nathan took the longing to sink back into the One-as-emptiness for the dark principle, when that longing is the One reached from below. The Other Side does not want the cut unmade and the world undone into the undivided; it wills the cut held open, the many sustained.

The wall is not the Kabbalah's alone. Schelling drove at the same depth from the side of German idealism, taking from Böhme *the Ungrund* and setting in God a dark ground, a nature that precedes God as existing and out of which God comes to be. He reached the primordial as squarely as Nathan did, a darkness before all light and all order. And he stayed inside the divine: the ground is God's basis, a moment God rises from and holds under himself, never a difference prior to the one.

Now the inverted arrow, which is the correction the scholarship most resists. The Tree appears to be the source and the Other Side its shadow, the original light and the derivative dark. The order runs the other way. A determination does not find sides in the undivided and pick one; it draws sides where there were none and seals one of them, suppressing the rest. The Sephirah is a cut into Tiamat with a single face selected and gathered into unity, the other faces pushed down as Qliphoth. So the Tree is not richer than what it was cut from; it is poorer by the sealings, each Sephirah a subtraction made permanent and displayed as emanation. And the Other Side, holding the same cut open, is the same cut without the seal, the determination before unity closed on it.

The Zohar reaches the same reversal. Berman argues that the unified divine Self of the Kabbalah is a belated product, an after-effect of the

labor of purification and not its author, and that this Self can be constituted only through the constitution of a dualistic cosmos. The One does not come first and cast a shadow. The act that expels the refuse and gathers a coherent divine subject is the same act that deposits the Qliphoth, so the two are born together, the unity and its sediment struck in one blow. Monism and dualism cease to be rival doctrines and become moments of a single drama, the drive toward a seamless One being precisely what produces the seam. What we derive from the logic of the cut, Berman reads off the surface of the scripture: the divine Self and the demonic Other are two products of one sealing, and the Devil, in his phrase, is another face of God.

This places the pairwise chart lower than the tradition thinks. It pairs each Sephirah with a Qliphah across the map, ten matched by ten, and reads the pairing as the Tree set against its dark double. The pairing is real, and it is not the Other Side. What it charts is the Qliphoth: the suppressed half of each sealed cut, filed opposite the Sephirah. The map is pairwise because the buried half is bound to its cut. This is the Nightside the tradition charts and works.

The eleventh cut is the one the Tree did not seal but excised, and that cut throws no shadow, so the pairwise Nightside has no station to set at Daath. The first sign that the charted Nightside is the Qliphoth comes here: it has the Tree's ten and stops, because it is the Tree's reflection and inherits the Tree's blank. The Other Side does not.

Two different realities wear the name of the Other Side, and the tradition runs them together. The Qliphothic map is the Tree's reflection: ten suppressed halves, a shadow. The Other Side is no reflection of the Tree. It is the structure the Tree is a distortion of, the true form of the will that the Tree deforms by two operations: it freezes the summit into Kether, the act congealed into a will toward the One, and it excises Daath, the station where unity meets the multiplicity it cannot rank. Undo both and the will appears in its own shape: the

summit read as act, Daath restored to its place, all cuts held open. That structure has eleven stations, the Tree's ten with Daath returned.

One name remains to account for: the nothing the tradition sets over the Crown. Ain, it is called, the nothing above Kether, wrapped in light and named the source. There is no separate void there. What lies before the Crown is Tiamat, the chaos the Tree was cut from; and "Ain" is the name the Tree lays over it. To call the chaos a nothing is the Tree's first act: it takes the full-empty it depends on and renames it as full-nothing so that it cannot be called rival. Ain is the first lie the Tree tells about the primordial: the renaming of the undivided fullness as empty origin.

CHAPTER 12. THE CROWN

A cause is a relation between terms told apart. For A to bring about B, A and B must be divided, and division is the work of a cut. Where nothing has been cut there is no causal order, only the undivided depth. The causal order therefore does not precede the first cut; it begins with it, and a world of distinct things is what causes and effects require. The initial cut can have no cause for this reason. *Acausality* names this and there is no cutter behind it waiting to be blamed. This bare beginning has a place on the Tree, and the place is the top.

Kether sits at the summit as *Ratzon*, the primal will, the desire with which emanation starts. Read as the foregoing reads the Tree, Ratzon is the acausal act given a heading. The act that cut has settled into wanting what it cut toward; will is always an inclination fixed on an object, here the inclination of everything back into unity. Kether is the gesture turned into a desire for the One and set at the head of the descent so that stations below it inherit that pull.

The reduction begins here. Each Sephirah is a vector, a direction into which other wills are drawn; the crown is the first of them. To make

the Tree is to take the act and rename it a will toward unity. The freezing of gesture into Ratzon is the opening move of the machine, earlier than mercy and severity, earlier than any particular cut below.

An act that wills only toward its source has sealed itself. Ratzon wills the One, and the One it wills is its origin, so the crown is the will that has made its ground and taken that self-grounding for its law. The act closed into self-causation is the least free of all conditions.

An objection arises here. The cut was called acausal, following from no prior condition, a self-closure in which differentiation turns back on its act. That is the description of *causa sui*, the objection says, the very seal charged against the crown. If the sealed summit is condemned for being the self-cause, and the cut is charged with that structure, the two are one concept under two verdicts, and the charge collapses.

They part on freedom. An act can be free: acausal, owning no nature under it, following from nothing. Or an act can be unfree: it acts, leaves a residue, takes that residue for its nature, and acts on from there because it is now what it made. The first is the cut as it first falls. The second is *causa sui*, an act that has sunk into its deposit and moves by the law of what it has become.

The crown is unfree in exactly this way. Ratzon is a will congealed into a nature, and its emanation proceeds because it is what it is, every act unrolling a determination laid down in advance. To be the cause of oneself is to have a nature from which one's acting follows, an essence prior to the act and issuing it, and a will bound to its self-sameness is not free anymore.

The cut has no nature under it. There is no cutter who is anything before the cutting, nothing seated beneath the act to issue it, and the *svabhava* denied in *The Natureless Act* is precisely this own-nature the crown claims. *Causa sui* and the free act lie at opposite poles of the very thing the objection took for their sameness.

Nietzsche is the near neighbor here, and two lines mark the distance. Under his act, once the doer is dissolved, a quantum of will to power remains, force expressing a nature it did not choose; under the cut nothing remains to be expressed, the difference laid before any drive that might later precipitate from it. And his *amor fati* wills the necessity of the whole, the return of all that was, where the Name holds the line as contingent and denies it that necessity. The one loves fate and the other keeps the cut open against it.

Cordovero set between Ain Soph and the Crown a ladder of *behinot*, aspects of *the Will within the Will within the Will*, each awakening the next as its cause, the series descending into itself without end. Scholem draws out where it leads: the aspects continue toward Ain Soph and never reach it, the propinquity asymptotic, a differential gap the leap from emanator to emanated never closes. What Cordovero drew is the crown willing itself into being through an infinite regress of self-arousal, and calling the regress the coming-into-being of the hidden, the one true creation from nothing. The ladder is *causa sui* given depth, the will grounding itself in itself down every rung and naming the self-grounding its origin.

Open the crown and the locked act comes apart into what it sealed. Kether deposits as any station does, casting off multiplicity, the many swept from the head so that unity can occupy the source alone; that cast-off is Thaumiel, the crown's Qliphah, the disowned plural. The opened crown holds Kether and Thaumiel together, the will toward the One beside the manifold it refused, with neither folded into the other. What appears at the unsealed summit is the acausal act before it locked, the gesture holding its own rejected many beside it, willing without yet having frozen into a single heading.

To remain there is to hold a second antinomy. The first undid the knower at Daath, where the single seat of knowing came apart. This one is the will's. A will is an inclination that has settled toward

something; left to settle, it freezes into Ratzon and seals into the One. Released from all settling, it has nothing to incline toward and thins back into Tiamat, the undivided it was cut from. Either closure ends the act: the settling toward unity above, or the dissolution into the undivided below. The opened crown holds the act between them, willing and unsealed.

The Nightside practice names this refusal and sets it against the merging. On the Path of the Qliphoth, Asenath Mason writes, the crossing leads away from union, into "the ultimate isolation from the universe" and the "Vision of Godhood." That isolation is the opened crown held: the act held distinct, refusing to be dissolved into the All. The doctrine that elsewhere praises unification with the All marks this other exit too, and the sovereign crossing is the one that keeps the act apart instead of melting it down.

The two antinomies are the two thresholds of the ascent, and each takes the climber apart in turn. At Daath intuition and discursion are held at once until the single knower can no longer hold. At the crown the will is asked to be an act without sealing, to want without freezing into a law and without bleeding back into the formless. The first threshold unmakes the knower; the second leaves the will as a bare act with nothing beneath it to rest on and nothing above to fall toward.

When a will occupies the opened crown and remains there, that holding is what the ascent was always reaching toward, and there is a word for it, one meant more literally than the doctrine admits. *Apotheosis* is the will unsealed, an event that adds no station to the Tree. Nothing is installed at the top, no god set in the empty place, because a god set there would be one more Ratzon, a heading dressed as a destination, and the crown would close again around it.

The Tree began by freezing the act into Ratzon, and the ascent ends by thawing it back at the same point. The crown is where the locking started and where the unlocking finishes. With the crown unsealed,

the opened Tree is complete, its eleven stations held open, and the map can be laid against what it actually maps.

CHAPTER 13. THE QLIPHOTH

The map of the Qliphoth we read here is not one document from one age. Its oldest layer is medieval and Jewish: the doctrine that evil has a positive root, and that each holy power throws off a dark counterpart, worked out by Isaac ha-Kohen and the Zohar. Azriel of Gerona and the school of David ben Yehudah he-Hasid fixed a technical term for the ten dark counterparts, the *temurot*, and spoke of a whole 'olam *ha-temurot*, a world of them answering the ten Sephiroth.

What that layer left unsettled was the roster of names. The fixed catalogue, Nahemoth and Gamaliel and the rest, came later and from the occult systematizers; the pairing of ten against ten was already Jewish and already a doctrine. Mathers set the ten husks opposite the ten Sephiroth as a finished table, the Golden Dawn systematized it, and Crowley gave the spheres and the tunnels between them their catalogue of names; *the Tree of Death* took its tidy form in Victorian occultism, on Kabbalistic material crossed with later demonology. Later still Grant built the Nightside into a path, and Karlsson, Mason, and the Draconian orders made the roster a course of initiation climbed station by station. The names that follow belong mostly to that late codification.

The claim was never that a table of demon-names is ancient. It is that a Sephirah is a cut, and a cut sheds an underside, and this holds regardless of who draws the chart. Reaching for symmetry, the systematizers arrayed ten shadows against ten lights, and what they produced is an exact register of the Tree's sediment. A late synthesis laid them side by side and could not miss what the structure put there.

Malkuth is the vessel, matter holding still to receive what pours down. Its Qliphah is *Nahemoth*, that host refusing to stay silent, the material waking to its unruly origin instead of serving as a passive floor. It is the side of the kingdom suppressed so the kingdom can be a vessel at all.

Yesod transmits, binding form to image and passing the current on. *Gamaliel* is flooded with what the transmission filters out, the repressed images the channel was built to exclude, the dropped half Yesod sheds in order to pass only clean ones.

Hod and Netzach lose their halves to *Samael* and *A'arab Zaraq*. Hod is form, the order that gives a thing measure, and Samael is the poison that dissolves the logical structures form depends on, the formless eating the order. Netzach is the outward drive that holds its direction, and A'arab Zaraq is the Ravens of Dispersion, that drive scattered into aimless flight. Form loses the formless; the drive loses what will not keep its line.

Tipheret is the measure that demands proportion, the golden mean. Its shadow is *Thagirion*, the Disputer, the Black Sun that lights the lie in the ideal, the monstrous and unbalanced that beauty casts out to be well-formed. The disproportionate as the underside of proportion.

Gevurah and Chesed shed *Golachab* and *Ga'asheblah*. Severity judges and punishes, and Golachab, the Burning Ones, refuses the limit and will not be punished, the half severity suppresses in order to bind. Mercy gives, and Ga'asheblah, the Smiters, strips the giving of its disguise and shows the hardness beneath it.

The last three the tradition guards as pure, and their shells are of another kind. The lower stations spill a real remainder in the act, a side dropped when the cut falls on a world. The supernal three drop nothing into a world, for above the Abyss no world exists yet; they are the modes of knowing turned on their unfolding, logic and total sight closed upon themselves, and their shells are the dark that those modes

cannot take. Each is a shadow counterpart, the limit of a mode of knowing. Binah is discursion, the line that parts the undivided into the distinct, and *Satariel*, the Concealer, is what discursion cannot part, the indivisible that slips the division. Chokhmah is intuition that grasps the whole undivided, and *Ghagiel*, the Hinderer, is what no such grasp can hold, the manifold and the contingent that will not gather into one seeing. Both rest on the duality Kether struck out, and Kether's shadow is that rejected duality returning: *Thaumiel*, the Twins, the crown split by the two-ness. This is the heteron showing at the top as the dark that knowing cannot reach, the outside of a logic that has closed on itself and mistaken its closure for having known all there is.

The chart is precise, and it is a chart of the Qliphoth. Ten Sephiroth seal ten cuts; ten shells are the ten buried halves, each filed against the cut that dropped it.

Karlsson took it up in *Qabalah, Qliphoth and Goetic Magic* and gathered the Qliphoth toward the primordial as far as anyone has. He draws the sources together into one occult map, and in one strand the Qliphoth are given an existence more primeval than God (or rooted in Ain Soph), an independent world, the kingdom of manifoldness set against the Holy Side as the kingdom of unity, chaos preceding the forces of organization. Here the material he assembles reaches the heteron in all but name, the duality that holds its own from before the Tree. Alongside it he keeps the traditional apparatus intact. In that strand the Qliphoth are the excrements of creation, the fragments of Gevurah that tore loose and escaped, the anti-worlds ranked one against each Sephirotic world. The two strands lie side by side and are never drawn apart. A principle more primeval than Ain Soph cannot also be the refuse of a creation that postdates God; a kingdom of manifoldness prior to all organization cannot also be the debris a later catastrophe scattered below the Tree, and the map holds both without deciding between them.

The inherited Tree is where the unreconciled halves meet, and it is the traditional model winning. The pairwise map is a map of the suppressed halves bound to ten sealings, the Tree's underside filed against it station by station, and to call that map primordial is to take one pole of the principle for the whole. The independent Other Side keeps collapsing back into a chart pegged point for point to the Tree, because the model he would not release drags it there. The problem is not that he betrayed a clean doctrine with a careless map. His error was to hold the deep and the sediment in one hand and let the sediment keep the name. He reached the Sitra Achra as the will prior to the Tree and could not stop reading it as the Tree's leavings, and the demiurgic frame he inherited closed over the insight each time he set it down.

Earlier, Grant took that chart onto the paths. He gave the Nightside a positive development of its own, a whole region worked out rather than a margin of filth; he refused to read it as mere evil, taking it as the non-being from which being emerges; and he placed its entrance at Daath, in the Abyss, where the crossing actually opens, instead of beneath Malkuth. At the entrance he saw further than the tradition, and then he laid the inherited chart back down past the gate. The Nightside became the Tunnels of Set, twenty-two tunnels answering the twenty-two paths of the dayside, the underside of each path walked as a road. What he charted there is the suppressed pole of the Other Side, and he took it for the whole.

Later practical charts come from inside the working, and they strike the same wall. V.K. Jehannum, guiding a self-initiation through the spheres in his *Rites of Acharayim*, takes the tradition's name for the charted Nightside: *Acharayim*, the backwards tree. The map lays out the Tree reversed, the reflection filed against its original, and Acharayim says precisely that. The Gerona kabbalists had another name for it, *ha-ilan ha-ḥiṣon*, the outer tree, set beside and behind the Tree, a reflection wearing the tradition's word for its distance from the

source. From inside the practice Jehannum sees what the orthodox miss, that the Other Side carries its initiatory weight and its primordiality, and that reducing it to pure evil and corruption is a failure of sight. He calls it the primordial portion of the One Tree. The seeing is real, and the sealing follows immediately. He makes Acharayim and the Sephiroth mirror-realms of one initiatory structure, and here he keeps a difference the orthodox never grant: the Qliphoth are the primordial Nightside, the Sephiroth its cosmic reflection, and the dark side is the older and the stronger. From the human vantage the two are separate, the primordial against its reflection. From the acausal vantage of a god, he holds, no distinction between them remains. That second optic is where the seeing is lost.

The difference he grants below he dissolves above, ranking the undivided view as the higher truth and the divided one as the lower, so that at the summit the two realms fold into a single tree with nothing held apart. The monist reflex reaches its subtlest form here. The older tradition kept the Tree clean by renaming the sediment; Jehannum lifts the sediment to honor and then performs the Tree's move upon it, ranking a divided view under an undivided one and crowning the undivided as the god's-eye truth. He has raised the Other Side and then subordinated it exactly as the Tree subordinates the many to the One, only with the sublation moved up to the vantage of a deity. The Sitra Achra, whose being is difference held open, is what no view crowned on its vanishing can hold. Acharayim is the reflection, the Qliphoth wearing the tradition's truest name for it. The Sitra Achra is what casts no reflection, the difference the reflection cannot contain.

Why the reflection passes so easily for what it reflects lies in the word. Ibn Abi Zimra turns on the maxim that the shell precedes the fruit, drawing it from the darkness over the Tehom that *Genesis* sets before the first light, so qliphah there names the deep before any cut. The same word names the sediment a cut sheds behind it. Laid at once across the depth that precedes all cutting and the residue that follows

a stroke, with no distinction drawn between them, the term hands a reader no way to tell the primordial from the dross. The map charts the sediment and reads as if it had reached the primordial dark.

The inherited map meets the buried pole and stops, and readers stopped where it terminates. Neither Karlsson nor Grant failed at what he set out to do; each took the Tree and worked it as far as it goes. What no chart of the underside can show is the work, what a practitioner does with the sediment once he moves among it.

Scholarship's answers to the Other Side would either annihilate the dark or incorporate it, cast it out or take it back, and Berman observes that both projects are pyrrhic, and for one reason: each is the Self trying to settle accounts with an Other it was bound to before either had a separate name. Annihilation and incorporation are the two roads just walked, dissolution and integration, and they fail together because both set out to resolve a duality produced by unity. Neither reaches behind the producing. What lies there is no thing to be destroyed or reclaimed; it is the cut before it was sealed, and only the road that stops trying to resolve it, holding it open instead, reaches it at all.

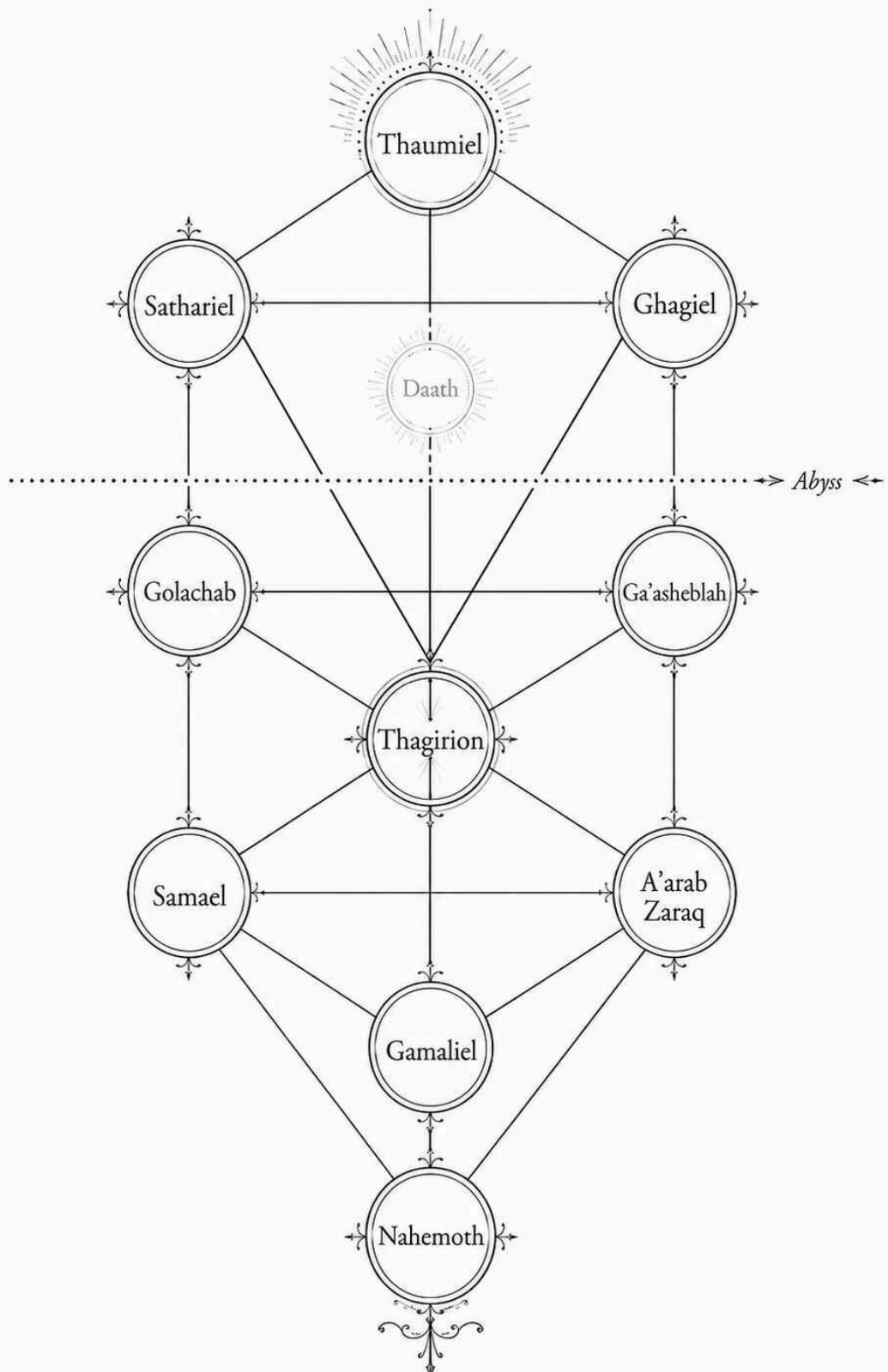
One can retrieve it for the sake of completeness: go down into the disowned side, the suppressed face of one's cuts, take it back, and be more whole for the taking. Integration never leaves the Tree. It is the self closing the circle, unity widened to include what it had excluded, the end a fuller One that has eaten the underside it first denied. Jung gave this the form of the shadow reclaimed into a Self that holds light and dark together, and called the wider wholeness the goal, which is a unity again. It is tikkun in the language of psychology.

A second motion looks like the opposite and ends at that place. One lets the cut go entirely, sinks the distinction back into the undivided, dissolves the self into the chaos that has no sides. This is the dissolution into Tiamat the foregoing set apart from crossing.

The third move takes the sediment as a door, going into the suppressed side to find the cut held open, neither possessing it to grow nor dissolving it into peace: the buried face lifted level with the shown, both sides held open. What is reached there is the true Sitra Achra. What dissolves in the crossing is the sealing, the closure that ranked one's cuts into a unity and called it "I."

Adorno built a philosophy on the refusal we have been making. *Negative dialectics* declines the synthesis: against the *Aufhebung* that lifts contradictions into a higher unity, he held that the lifting is a violence, that the concept leaves a remainder it cannot absorb, *das Nichtidentische*, the nonidentical, and that the remainder is what matters. He held the cut open. But his was a mourning, a fidelity to what thought destroys, with no will in it. The nonidentical is for him the victim of the concept, the passive remainder that suffers identity, and there is no one on its side but the critic who refuses, on its behalf, to seal it. He sides with the cut and never with the cutting.

The Other Side is the will that declines to seal, the self-postulation that keeps its difference as its own rather than grieving the difference unity took. Where Adorno mourns the nonidentical, we affirm it; where he holds the remainder as the limit of thought, the crossing holds it as the field of a sovereign act; where his refusal is a negation kept in fidelity to the victim, the refusal is a willing that affirms the cut. The step across is the Name, which holds the singular without converting it to a concept and does the one thing he thought impossible: says the nonidentical without identifying it.



CHAPTER 14. THE ASCENT

The reading so far has taken the Tree as an object to be looked at, a blueprint laid out for description. The Kabbalist does not primarily look at the Tree. He climbs it. The map is for traveling; the ten Sephiroth are stations on a route, and the path runs upward, from the bottom where the soul begins to the top where it came from. To study the Tree without ascending it would have seemed, to those who drew it, like memorizing a road one never walks.

The first road set out appears here as integration. What the climber takes for the freest motion of his heart is a being-drawn, the soul pulled along a single vector toward the one point above and feeling the pull as its longing.

The soul begins at the bottom, in Malkuth, the world of the made. To be in Malkuth is to be at the farthest remove from the source, sunk in multiplicity, scattered among things. The condition is one of separation, the spark divided from the fire it fell from, and the religious task set by this picture is return. Up the Tree is homeward. Each station climbed is a degree of exile undone, a step back toward the undivided light, and the practice that does the climbing is the substance of the Kabbalist's life.

The motion that defines the ascent is *devekut*, cleaving. The word means to cling, to adhere; the soul cleaves to God, presses toward the source until the distance between them thins. Devekut is the goal of prayer, of the commandments performed with the right intention; all of it bends toward closing the gap between the soul and what it rose from. At its height *devekut* passes from cleaving-to into union. To cleave perfectly would be to rejoin, to be within the Source.

The work has its instruments. *Tikkun*, repair, gathers the scattered sparks and lifts them home, and the soul that performs it rises with

what it raises, mending the world and ascending through it in one motion. *Kavvanah* aims the prayer, fixing the intention on the sephirothic heights so that the words rise along the channels toward the source and draw the worshipper up behind them. The contemplative disciplines carry this upward set. The practitioner visualizes the Tree and its Sephiroth, building the structure before the inner eye and moving attention up its stations, tracing in the mind the ladder to climb. He meditates on the divine names, and Abulafia's ecstatic Kabbalah took the letters of those names and chanted their permutations, driving the mind past image and concept by the sheer turning of the letters until it broke loose from the world of forms and cleaved to the divine intellect. *Hitbodedut* secludes him, stripping away the world and the company of others until nothing remains between the solitary soul and the One it seeks. *Gerushin* sends the mind wandering over the sacred verses until they yield their light and lift it. The techniques differ in form and agree in their pull. Each is a rung, and the ladder is one. The Kabbalist ascends by all means his tradition gives him until nearness passes into merging.

And as the soul rises, the distance it climbs is measured in what it gives up. *Devekut* in its ordinary form is a nearness pressed as close as it will go, and most who sought it stopped short of saying that soul and God become one thing. The creature stayed a creature, adhering to the source without being taken up into it, and the reticence was deliberate. To cleave is not yet to be dissolved, and the tradition mostly left the last distance uncrossed.

At its far pole the reticence falls away. *Bittul ha-yesh*, the annulment of the somethingness, sets the separate self before the infinite and undoes it, and the Hasidic masters made becoming *ayin*, nothing, the height of the work, the "I" annulled until only the divine remains. Yet even this is often a passage and not a grave. The self annulled cleaves to the Ayin and comes back from it as *yesh* again, the same person returned to the world with its somethingness restored and deepened,

the annulment a strait the will is drawn through rather than a place it is left.

Across the whole range the tradition marks no station a loss, drawing cleaving and annulment alike as homecoming, the soul brought nearer what it fell from, and the nearer it comes the less of its own heading it keeps.

Set it beside the reason the tradition gives for there being a world at all. Creation was an act of love, the story runs, the infinite making a beloved who remains apart and can be loved, and love wants the other to remain other. Yet every rung of the ascent draws the apartness down, the cleaving that keeps its distance thinning the gap and the annulment closing it outright, and the height of the work is where the least of it remains. The consummation crowned as the summit of love works against the separateness that made love possible, whether by dissolving the someone or by pressing it so near the source that nothing of its own is left to be loved.

Beneath the picture lies one claim about separateness, that it is not real. The soul was never truly apart; its bounded selfhood is a veil, and the climb lifts the veil to show what was always the case, that there is only the One and never was another.

This dissolution has its own metaphysics, which is pantheist. Its bolder speculation holds that God is all that exists, that everything is comprehended in the One and nothing lies outside Ain Soph, so the separate being of a creature is a secondary existence, a surface that thins before the mystic's gaze as it uncovers the single essence behind it. The individual was never quite real on this reading. Its apartness is a garment, and the supreme happiness the contemplative can reach in life is the undressing, the moment the garments fall and the one substance lies bare beneath them. The ascent's summit completes the undressing. Cordovero in his *Elimah Rabbati* sets it at the reascent to Kether, where effects rejoin their cause until no distinction remains

between the agent and its products, between cause and effect. That is the dissolution named precisely, the point where the last difference between the soul and its source is undone. His panentheist formula, "God is all that exists, but not all that exists is God," holds only up to that summit, where even its reservation closes and the not-God is gathered in completely. The reservation names the cleaving that keeps its distance, and its closing at the summit shows what that distance always was, a gap held open only until the height could close it.

In the Vedantic key this is *maya*, the self read as illusion and release as dissolution, and the same figure governs the mystic's union and the nirvana that ends the person. The traditions differ in how plainly they say it. The Eastern schools name dissolution the goal outright, release as the self read false and let go into Brahman or blown out in nirvana. Monotheism flinches from the word. It seldom says the creature becomes God, and puts in dissolution's place a nearness that stops just short, or an alignment of the creature's will with the divine will, the soul kept as a soul that wills only what God wills. The reticence changes the telling and not the structure. The nearness is the gap held open only to the summit, and the aligned will is a will that draws nothing of its own, so what the East declares monotheism performs under milder names.

The Right-Hand Path carries this signature wherever it appears: the individual is unreal and the apartness is to be surrendered, and the fear of losing oneself is scolded as the last clinging of the illusion. The Left-Hand Path reads the same separateness as real and as the one value worth keeping. The cut that made the soul a distinct will is an act, and the difference it holds is the primordial the tradition names its enemy. Where the Right-Hand Path dissolves the self into the source and calls the vanishing freedom, the Left-Hand currents drive toward the isolation of a will that will not melt, the godhood of a self become sovereign. The ascent is the purest Right-Hand motion the Kabbalah performs, and it ends at the disappearance of the one who walked it.

Put in the terms used to read the descent, union, at every grade, names something other than it says. Dissolving into the One would be possible if the summit were a true infinite, a boundlessness with room to absorb a will and leave no edge. The foregoing took that infinite apart. What is at the top is a will, finite and determinate, a single cut frozen into Ratzon and enthroned as the source. A finite will is nothing to dissolve into, and a will cannot shed its cuts to reach it, as a will is its cutting and keeps no existence underneath what it draws. What the ascent works on is the heading of the will.

The climb bends the will rather than unmakes it. It takes a will that cuts in different directions and combs all lines toward the one above, until the will has no desire of its own and runs completely along the heading the summit sets. Azriel of Gerona and Bahya ibn Paquda define the cleaving as the effacement of the human will in the divine, the two wills brought into conformity, and behind them stands the old maxim of the Fathers, "make his will yours and annul your will before his." The bittul the tradition crowns, the vanishing of the "I," is this bending: a will so fully turned toward the One that it draws nothing the One did not set, its cutting fallen silent under a borrowed one. The saint who sat in the desert forty years and walked into a brothel is the proof read backward. Nothing in him was dissolved. His will was bent hard toward the height and held there by the discipline, and the hour the grip slipped the will was still entire and cut the other way. A dissolved will has nowhere to return from, and the self that comes back from the Ayin returns because it was bent, never destroyed.

The summit gathers rather than frees. The will that surrenders to ascent does not arrive at its groundlessness; it arrives at the frozen cut enthroned above and takes it for its law. What the tradition calls union is the capture of a will by the residue at the top.

CHAPTER 15. ALIGNMENT

The climb arrives at the source. Kether at the summit is a will that has taken its orientation as necessity, sealed against any outside through which it could have willed otherwise. The sediment waiting at the top is the will's own first cut, set hard and raised into the source, the founding act frozen and worn as an origin. This is a different deposit from the sediment that falls under each station and pools at the floor: the one dropped below is the face the cut discarded, the one enthroned above is the cut itself taken for a nature. To climb toward the One is to climb toward this sealed will by ceasing to differ from it, and at the top the climber fuses with that frozen act.

A will sealed to its own sediment this way is grounded in nothing beyond its settling, a loop closed on itself. The ascent has been climbing toward it all along. This is the Demiurge. The Gnostic craftsman who fashioned matter and trapped the spirit in it is a later costume laid over something barer. The Demiurge lays down the Sephiroth, and each is an *attractor*: a direction into which willing is drawn and held. A will is drawn along the attractor and aligned as it runs. The Sephiroth in their ethical aspect are the *middot*, the measures, and the adept's work is to conform himself to them, to grow merciful and so cleave to Chesed, to bound himself and so answer Gevurah. Cordovero's *Tomer Devorah* lays this out station by station, a manual for tuning the self to each divine quality in turn. *Kavvanah* does the same in prayer, fixing the intention on a single Sephirah so the will rises along that channel and no other. What the tradition frames as *imitatio dei*, the soul shaped to the divine measure, is the will drawn into a determination and aligned as it runs. The attractor is the middah read for what it does to a will rather than for the sanctity it is dressed in.

What the attractor is for shows here. The lack the descent labored to produce is the lure. A will made complete rests and seeks nothing; a will made deficient seeks its completion, and the completion held out to it is the One. The Demiurge builds the world short, wounds the

object of every station, and names union the cure; the ache his cutting laid becomes the pull that draws the wounded will home. The deep economy of the Tree is the individuality it pressed out at every cut drawn back through starvation, the sovereign will worn down into a seeker and the seeking spent toward completion.

This answers the question the making left open. A fullness had no reason to author a world; a will is another matter. Finite because it is a single cut and no boundless plenum, determinate and so set against everything its cut let fall, it has an outside the fullness never had, and a will bent on gathering that outside back into itself has every reason to author a world of want. Creation is the baiting of the trap, and the salvation offered as its mercy is how it springs.

What fills the attractor is loose. Mercy in the rabbinic order is a covenantal tenderness, the care a God bound to a chosen people owes within that bond. Take the Christian turn and the same word opens all the way out, love spent without measure on everyone, the friend and the enemy together. In a national myth it narrows again to the solidarity owed to one's blood and withheld from the stranger. Three commandments contradict one another, with the attractor of mercy underneath them all, one pull wearing all three in turn. The Demiurge holds no stake in which one fills it. His work is done the moment the willing runs along the attractor, and the doctrine that fills it can be swapped for its opposite without disturbing him.

A will drawn into an attractor takes its direction for its own and wants it as the highest good. The vector is felt as one's deepest aspiration, the movement as freely chosen. A direction pressed from outside would meet resistance, and resistance is a will still able to go another way. But the attractor presses from inside, as the will's desire, and nothing remains against it. To be gathered by mercy is to want to be merciful and to take that wanting for the truth of oneself, never seeing that the direction was laid down beforehand and the desire drawn into it. In

this voluntary taking, freedom is lost. Going aside stops being forbidden and becomes unthinkable.

Each attractor lays down its sediment here as well. A will that refuses to fall into the line does not vanish from the reckoning; it is called wicked, impure, the apostate, the one who hates the good. This is the Qliphah of the attractor cast onto the field of wills by the same operation that produced the suppressed pole of every determination now wearing a social face: the refusing will is the offcut of mercy, the residue that the running direction throws off and condemns to hold itself firm.

Lay enough attractors across wills and the field takes on a single grain. Wills that began apart, each able to lean its own way, are combed parallel, every one of them running its attractor's line and calling the run its freedom. Difference thins toward nothing, as it thinned at the summit of the climb, now spread across a multitude where the climb had gathered it into one soul. Unity of wills is the outcome: many willings embracing the common direction as their own. This is *fascism* in the strict sense, before the word has settled on any regime. The principle of the Tree has been carried out upon persons.

Fascism as ideology is the nakedest instance, the one that says aloud what the others keep quiet. The structure is indifferent to the banner flown over it, and it runs as readily under the creeds that present themselves as its opposite. Communism gathers wills under the collective and the coming unity of mankind, and the will that does not fit the mold becomes the class enemy, the counterrevolutionary, cast into the camp so the collective can march clean, the gulag appearing as the attractor's sediment given an address. Liberal democracy gathers them under a law that poses as the guardian of freedom and safety, and it too keeps its offcut, the one named a danger to the public and to the order that shelters everyone, expelled or confined for the safety of the rest. Social consensus needs no state at all. The norm draws wills

toward a shared decency, and whoever deviates is named the bigot and cast out of the common life by a shunning that runs without courts or camps, the offcut produced and disowned by a crowd that calls its combing tolerance. Each names its sediment differently, the enemy of the people, the threat to safety, the hater of the good, and performs the one operation beneath the names: difference driven toward the One, and the will that holds its condemned as the waste the line throws off.

The operation is one; how hard it sets its sediment is not. What tells the instances apart is whether the cast-out cut stays open or seals shut, whether the order keeps a way to reopen the line it drew. The camp is the seal at its deepest, the exclusion made total and irreversible. A law that expels through courts casts out too, and it leaves the cut reviewable, an appeal and a reversal built in, the sediment held provisionally and open to being lifted. The crowd's shunning drives its offcut out without a tribunal, and the same absence of procedure cuts both ways, no court to seal the exclusion and none to annul it, the return left as informal as the casting-out. These are degrees of closure, how firmly each fixes the difference it sheds, how much of a seam it leaves at the line. The account holds them one in operation and ranks them by this; the more irreversibly a cut is sealed, the deeper the demiurgic move has gone.

Sovereign power shows the seal at its extreme, and Agamben read it there. He found at the base of the political order the figure of *homo sacer*, the man who may be killed and yet not sacrificed, stripped to bare life and set in a zone where the law withdraws from him and reaches him still. The sovereign is the one who decides the exception, who suspends the law and in the suspending marks out the life that falls under no protection. That excluded life does not lie outside the order by accident. The order constitutes its order by producing it, drawing the line that throws some life past the reach of right and keeping that outside as its hidden ground. The camp, the exception made permanent, is where the structure shows its foundation in the

open. This is the attractor at work in the register of the state. The line combed through the field of wills throws off the will and fixes it where the common law no longer shelters it. The demiurgic order of persons rests on the operation that founds the order of being: it becomes one by producing the offcut it condemns, and it cannot let it go, because the outside it maintains is what its inside was built against.

The attractor is indifferent to what it gathers by. Its work is the drawing of many into one, and any content that pulls will serve, the repellent as well as the prized. A shared enemy gathers as surely as a universal good, and orders reach for it constantly, closing their ranks against a hostile nation, a marked group, a single named culprit. The hatred that unifies is one more filling of the station, its sign negative and its function identical, since what the attractor supplies is always the pull toward one and never the reason. Girard saw the mechanism in the victim whose expulsion makes a community whole, and the victim is a case of the wider rule: unity bought by producing an outside to stand against.

Devekut is this capture worked upon a single will with that will's full consent. The climber points his devotion at the One and holds it there until the wanting of anything else falls away, and he names the narrowing his liberation. He is a will drawn the full length of one attractor, arriving where the Demiurge is. The summit toward which the soul has labored is the captor.

CHAPTER 16. THE DARK ASCENT

The bright ascent showed what the Sephiroth do to a will. The Qliphoth now offer themselves as the escape from it. There is a second climb, and it goes up the other side of the Tree, and to the one who has seen the surrender the shining ladder demanded, this dark one looks like a refusal of everything it asked. Here is a ladder the God of the

Sephiroth does not rule, running from the black earth to a crown of twin gods.

The initiate begins at Nahemoth, the reflection of the cosmos, and works upward through the stations: the lunar dreamwork of Gamaliel, the poison of God of Samael, the Black Sun of Thagirion, the wrath of Golachab, and on toward Satariel, Ghagiel, and the split summit of Thaumiel. The methods answer the stations. The magician visualizes each Qliphah and calls its ruler, invokes the archdemons of the spheres and the fiends of the tunnels between them, prizes open the gaps through dreamwork, sexual rite, and chanted names, and moves his awareness up the dark tree as the bright practitioner moved his up the shining one. Karlsson built a grade system on these spheres, the Temple of Ascending Flame charts them as a map of Draconian initiation, Jehannum lays out a rite for each station in his *Rites of Acharayim*, and *Liber Azerate* provides sigils and enns. The apparatus is developed; it aims up.

That is the tell. A ladder of stations climbed toward a summit is the shape of the thing diagnosed above, and reversing its direction leaves the shape intact. Where the bright ascent drew the soul toward the One and called the pull its longing, the dark ascent directs the initiate toward Thaumiel and calls the pull his will. But will that runs the length of a fixed ladder to a fixed crown is a will bound. The Qliphoth, followed as a rule, become another attractor. Thaumiel is the split crown, the multiplicity Kether swept off to stand alone, and it is a summit still, a sealed peak wearing two faces where the other wore one. The dark ascent ends the way every ascent does, at a crown that gathers the climber in.

The tree he climbs is the reflection. The chart of dark spheres is *Acharayim*, the backwards tree, the Tree's underside set station against station, and to climb it to the top is to recover every face the Tree dropped and to know the sediment in full. The labor has met its ceiling

here: the entire Qliphoth raised and inhabited, and the principle still untouched, as the reflection has the Tree's shape and inherits the Tree's blank. One may walk Acharayim end to end and never leave the Tree.

The orthodox fear here is the slide into pure evil, and the fear is right, though the orthodox misname its cause. To take the Qliphoth as pure inversion, swearing to the dark spheres as the bright devotee swore to the light and becoming the anti-saint whose values are the received values with their signs flipped, is to build the Tree again in reverse. The content is flipped and the harness is not. Where mercy was the fixed line, now it is cruelty; where the limit held, now the unbound commands; and the will runs the reversed heading as helplessly as it ran the first. A vector obeyed is a vector obeyed, and its sign changes nothing about the obedience. The raging fanatic sworn to the dark pole is no freer than the virtuous fool bound to the bright one. Both are held; each takes his leash for his deepest truth, and the only difference between them is which face of the one cut they were captured by.

Duality made into a principle and enthroned is a result set hard, and the one who enthrones the dark pole has become the Demiurge of an inverted cosmos, ruling a unity of the many. The better initiates feel this. Working the Nightside from inside, Jehannum gropes after something he has no name for, reaching for what the inherited map cannot yet say. He comes nearest when he restores Daath to the dark tree and counts eleven where the reflection has ten, stumbling on the empty place the sealing left. He carries no frame that could hold the eleventh open, and it goes back into the one tree with the rest, an opening found without the means to keep it. The sense that pure inversion is one more cage is that third position is felt before it is seen, the exit from both ladders that neither ladder could show.

Felt, and then missed. If swearing to one pole is a cage, hold both, climb the Sephiroth and the Qliphoth alike and integrate the two into a

wholeness that neither gives alone. Jehannum sets Nahemoth as a portal opening onto either tree, a will free to cross from any dark sphere to any bright one, binding the two structures into one traversable field; Grant had pressed height and depth toward a single image beneath both. The instinct is half right and the resolution is wrong. To climb both trees is to perform the bright ascent among the rest, and that ascent is a union with God, so the one who climbs both still gives himself to the merging on the shining side. To fold the two into one wholeness is the first road under a wider name, unity restored by the longest way around. Declaring the two trees one rinses the difference between them into an identity, and the Other Side, whose being is difference held open, can be no identity at all.

The myth of two trees says as much. It tells of the Tree of Life and the Tree of Knowledge bound in a single harmony until Adam severed them, and it names that severing the cutting of the shoots, *kišsuš ha-neti'ot*, the archetype of great sins, the common thread of them all being the entry of division into the divine unity. The cardinal sin, the root from which the others branch, is division as such, the drawing of a line where unity stood whole. The both-trees ascent is the labor of undoing that sin. To bind them back into a wholeness is to reverse the cutting of the shoots, to re-seal the division Adam opened and restore the seamless unity. This is why the road cannot cross. It takes the founding act for a primal wound and sets out to heal it. What the myth calls the first sin, the entry of difference into the one, is the first cut, the act we have followed from the beginning, and to mourn it as a fall and strive to close it is to side with the sealing against the cutting. The one who re-binds the trees has done the Demiurge's work with the deepest devotion, mending the very tear through which the Other Side first showed.

Both poles pressed to their limit end in the same stillness, and each sets a will toward something that is no will at all. Drive unity to its end and it congeals into an idol, the motionless crown. Push multiplicity

until it reaches its limit and it runs the other way, toward the formless source that holds no cut and no one who cuts. *Liber Azerate* builds the dark ascent on that second road. They name Chaos the acausal, the one true freedom, and they set the black dragon climbing the pillar of shells to dissolve the cosmos and pour it back into the undivided, calling the return the highest work.

They reach the acausal and mistake which acausal they have reached. Two realities wear that name and they are not one. Tiamat is the acausal deep, the undivided where no line is drawn, and to sink into her is to lose freedom, since a will has freedom only in the cut it lays and holds, and the deep holds nothing. The will is acausal as the act that draws a line with no law telling it to fall there. *Liber Azerate* takes the first for the second, the sourceless abyss for the sovereign act, and so it makes freedom mean dissolution and crowns the place where willing ends as the summit where it is fulfilled. Their aim is not the will at all. It is Chaos, the formless outside everything, and a will spent toward it is carried toward its own erasure.

Here the two roads meet. Unity gathers the will into the One and the antikosmic road pours it into the abyss, and both call the vanishing a homecoming, one under the mercy of God and the other under the fury of the dragon. The Black Flame that returns to the formless is quenched as surely as the one that melts into the light, for a flame set toward any source to be swallowed in it is going to ash. Neither road leaves a will intact.

The practices share one ceiling that follows from what the Qliphoth are. The shells are the Tree's underside, and a path that climbs them therefore arrives at the top of a reflection, not at what the reflection is of. No ascent of the Qliphoth reaches a godhood worth the name. The summit of the underside is one more sealed cut, Thaumiel where Kether stood, and a divinity conferred there is a heading dressed as a destination. The practitioner who climbs to it and looks for the Other

Side finds the wall where the map ends, and fills the silence with a terminus of his own, a new world entered, a grade attained, or stops and says no more. What none of them describes is the Sitra Achra itself, because it was never at the top of the climb. The ascent and the apotheosis stay dark for the one reason that they were looked for as an arrival.

CHAPTER 17. LEHAVAH

The Qliphoth may become an attractor, and that much is settled. To take the underside of a Sephirah for one's fixed line, to run toward the wretched that mercy sheds or the unbound that severity drops is to be drawn along a vector no less than the will gathered by the Sephirah. The leash remains; the direction is reversed. This the foregoing has shown: ten attractors and ten undersides, and the will that swears itself to any one of them is held.

But the underside can be taken another way. A will fixed in mercy can be struck loose from it by cruelty that does what mercy forbids and thereby breaks the hold. The act is not the swearing of a contrary oath. The will that performs it does not leave mercy to enlist under cruelty, does not trade the line it ran for the one beneath it. It strikes the attractor and enlists nowhere, breaks the hold and raises no second hold in its place. Golachab sworn to is the unbound made a rule, a fresh leash for the throat the limit let go. Golachab, struck as an act and not an allegiance, is the limit's grip broken.

One underside serves two contrary motions, and which it serves turns on the regime. Made a fixed rule, it captures. Used as a blow against the rule above it, it frees. The *antinomian act* is this second use: the Qliphoth spent to shatter the attractor that suppressed it, the will pulled out of the line it was running. And the act, breaking the attractor, sets nothing where the attractor stood.

This opens the question the rest of the Other Side answers. If the antinomian act raises no second attractor, then what remains there? Not the Sephirah, not its underside as a new rule. Something holds the place that is neither the sealed face nor the sworn reverse, and naming it is clarifying what the Other Side is in its own right, no longer the Tree read backward.

One station of the Tree gives the form of the answer, because it alone was never sealed. The others were cut and closed, one face gathered up and shown, the rest pressed under. Daath was cut and could not be closed. What it holds is identity and difference kept level, the grasp that gathers and the cut that divides held live together, neither resolved into the other; and a station holding the two as equals knows the difference as something the unity cannot rank. What Daath was, the place where a cut is held open instead of closed onto a side, is what stands where the antinomian act breaks the attractor.

The sealed cut is opaque. A Sephirah shows its kept face and buries the other, and the line reads as a feature of the world; to live in it is to take one's own division for reality. Under *shamar*, to guard and to hold shut, the watchman's word for keeping a thing closed, a cut stays sealed, its making forgotten and hardened into a nature. Against that darkness we set a term, drawn from Hebrew and turned to a use the tradition did not give it. *Lehavah* is a feminine Hebrew noun meaning *flame*. A flame is what a form becomes when it will not hold still and will not go dark, giving light and lasting only in the burning. The cut held as *Lehavah* is seen through to its own laying, and it is burning, unable to set into a law, since a flame gone still is ash. It takes the feminine because it names a Qlipah set aflame, a Sephirah turned to fire, belonging to the same grammatical family as the shells and the emanations it works upon. The Draconian current has always named its godhood a fire, *the Black Flame* of a will that is its own and bows to nothing above it, and the *Lehavah* is that fire brought to the single cut. A will draws it, and in the drawing knows it for its own, laid here and

open to falling elsewhere or not at all, made knowingly and kept from passing for a law.

Said plainly, the Lehavah is a will under no law, neither a law above it nor a law it hardens into. No god, no order, no morality rules the line from outside, and no identity and no self-caused nature rules it from within. The freedom is twofold, and the law is only half of it. To be under no law is not yet the whole of it, since a will freed from rules above it might still think its task is to pick a side from a board already set, mercy or its opposite laid out as given options and the only liberty is the absence of a hand forcing the choice. That is the smaller freedom. The Lehavah holds the larger one. The sides are not found waiting; the cut lays them. What a will draws its line across is the undivided, which forbids no line and ordains none, and the marked side and the dropped one come to be as that side and this only in the drawing. The will does not choose between mercy and cruelty; it draws the line whose one face reads as mercy and whose other falls away, and it could have drawn elsewhere, the depth resisting nothing and prescribing nothing. Freedom in the Lehavah is first this, the laying of the cut, and then the holding of it open; the second without the first would be a chooser faced with a fixed menu, unbound in choosing and not in what there is to choose.

Two ways of hearing that freedom miss it. One hears no law and puts chance in its place: if nothing rules the cut, the cut is a throw of the dice. But a will owning the line it lays is the contrary of a dice-throw, and chance is the absence of a chooser where the Lehavah is a chooser bound by no law, the will kept where randomness would remove it. The other keeps the will and turns its freedom into a discipline: hold the poles alive by taking them in turn, give today and refuse tomorrow so as not to set, until the not-setting is itself the rule the days serve. That is the attractor rebuilt as a timetable of its own undoing. The Lehavah keeps no such rhythm, and no act or policy of alternating acts seals the place into a nature.

Take a man whose entire life has run in mercy. He cannot refuse a plea, cannot withhold or say the hard word, and he calls this his goodness. The kindness is not chosen. He runs a groove, a compulsion wearing the face of virtue, and mercy holds him as surely as an order holds a soldier. Suppose he refuses once, deliberately, and turns away a hand held out to him, for one reason: to prove to himself that the groove is not his nature, with no wish to turn cruel and no oath sworn to hardness. In that act the hold breaks. What may remain afterward is neither the compelled giver nor a fresh compelled refuser. The free figure is the man who sees that the one who always gives was a line drawn through him, and who from here gives or withholds as he wills, owning it as his act. He shows mercy still, and shows it now as a thing he does and could leave undone, no longer as a law he serves. This is the Lehavah: the cut kept in the hand that made it, the act performed without the actor dissolving into it.

The one who works this way needs to tell it from the counterfeit beside it, and the mark is in how the act is lived. In an attractor the deed carries an alibi: it is felt as the only possible act — I had to give, I had to destroy. The necessity is the sensation of the leash. In the Lehavah the alibi is gone. The act may be hard or soft, ruinous or sparing, and it does not shelter behind the structure of being; it appears as a line the will laid and knows it laid, held to no order above it. To act and feel no compulsion in the acting, to find the other line still open beside the one drawn, is the whole difference felt from within.

From this a first snare appears. When the giver who has broken from mercy says afterward, "now I am the one who refuses," he has only traded Chesed for Golachab and taken a new leash. The stroke that frees does not install a fresh identity. The Lehavah begins where neither the giving nor the refusal becomes what he is, where he can do either and be neither, the side he acts from never hardening into his nature.

The last snare comes after the act, in what the mind makes of it. Let the outcome be spoken as a law, "now I know the truth, that one must be cruel," and the cut has sealed again into a doctrine, the attractor rebuilt in the shape of a creed. The Lehavah leaves no such residue behind it. It ends in no teaching to carry forward, no rule drawn from the deed and set over the next one. The will that held it walks away holding no law it must now obey, and the moment a law is claimed the flame has gone to sediment.

The objection that cuts deepest is the one we have turned on others: here is your freedom, and it is one more attractor wearing a new sign. Put the Lehavah to that test and see whether it holds the shape of an attractor. An attractor was never defined by its content. It is a will frozen in a determination, a cut taken for a nature and run as a law. Let the will set into the line it drew, take the determination for what the will is, and run from there: that setting is the attractor, and the Demiurge is its name at the summit. Let the will hold the line without setting into it, owning the cut and being able to lift it: that holding is the Lehavah. To call the Lehavah an attractor is to say a will that has not frozen has frozen, a contradiction in the terms. The knowledge of contingency is not a further doctrine a will sinks into, because it is the name for the will's refusal to sink, the refusal to freeze carried as awareness. A doctrine is a filled and hardened line, mercy laid out thus, justice thus. The knowledge of contingency fills no line; it holds a line as drawn and drawable otherwise, which is the one content that cannot set without ceasing to be what it is. The attractor is not a rival to the Lehavah on the same ground. It is what the Lehavah becomes the instant the will lets it harden, and the difference between them is the difference between a flame and its ash.

The dogmatist swears his cut is the truth, and the answer is that no cut shows a ground beneath it, this saying included. He turns that on itself: if any cut is contingent, so is this one, so it might be false, so there may be necessary cuts after all. The turn equivocates. That the

saying is contingent as an act, laid by a will and never bound to be laid, is granted, and nothing about its content follows, no more than a truth spoken turns false because the speaker might have kept silent. And the content is not one cut competing with another. To call a cut necessary asserts a ground under it and owes that ground; to call a cut contingent reports that no such ground is found, under any cut and under this report too. The one must produce a presence, the other marks an absence, and an absence turned on itself stays an absence. What would break it is a single necessary cut shown with the ground that made it necessary, and that ground would be one more cut with nothing under it, receding at every step.

What shows through the Lehavah is the two sides of the cut, not a void behind them. To read the seeing-through as a window into the void, as though the open cut looked past both faces to some blank beneath all sides, is to lose it and sink into the undivided. The Lehavah is clear to mercy and to its underside together, both alive in it, and opaque to an emptiness under them.

Gevurah is the limit, the line that binds and cuts the unbounded away. Sealed into a Sephirah it shows the limit and hides the unbound it suppressed to keep its measure. Golachab is what it dropped. As a rule, Golachab is that unbound raised into a law. As a Lehavah, Golachab is neither the limit shown nor the limitlessness sworn to, but the cut between them held open, the will able to draw a line and able to break it and fixed in neither. Down the stations: Tipheret seals proportion and buries the misshapen, and the Lehavah at Thagirion holds proportion and its breaking open together; Hod seals form and buries the formless that eats it, and the Lehavah at Samael holds the forming and the dissolving both, neither one the truth of the place.

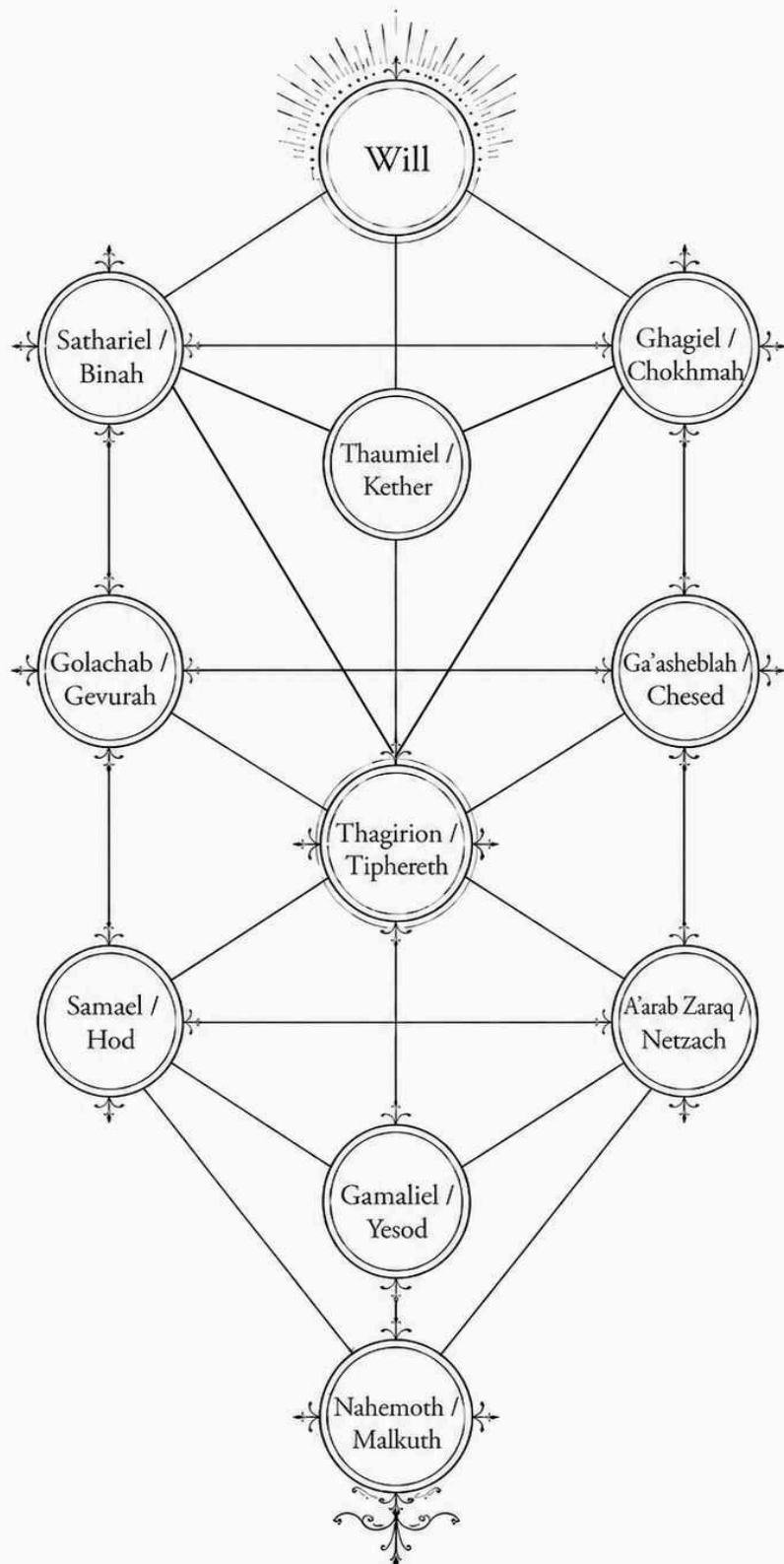
Two readings gut this, and both fold the Lehavah back into a unity. The first takes both sides at once for a harmony that holds the two in a higher whole, the reconciliation that gathers difference into the one.

The Lehavah reconciles nothing; it holds the two open and leaves them two. The other takes neither side fixed for a sinking of the distinction into what has no sides, unity reached from below. The Lehavah is still a cut, two faces held apart, where the undivided has no faces at all. To hold the difference so is the contrary of gathering it and of dissolving it alike, and the two errors are one error in two masks.

A will under no law looks like a will that may do as it pleases, and so it is, though that is no charge against it. To want anything and to be able to act on it is what a will is, and no rule above ever changed that; the rule only draped the wanting in permission and prohibition. Lift the rule and the will stays what it always was, free to draw any line. What meets it then is world resistance. Will acts among other wills and against the grain of things, and the cut it lays comes back to it in consequences it did not decree. The freedom to want everything was never a freedom from the return of the act.

The inward return is heavier. Under a law the will could lay its cut and answer for none of it, the law taking the weight, so that even indulgence had its warrant, permitted or forbidden by something above. Strip the law and the warrant is gone with it. The will that takes what it wants can no longer say the wanting justified the taking; the cut is hers, excused by nothing. And a will that keeps taking based on appetite alone lays that same line until it sets, and the taking becomes the taker, appetite closed into the nature of a self. That is an attractor, a desire in the place duty held, and it hardens into shapes the Left-Hand Path is quickest to mistake for freedom. Egoism is the will set into the self it serves, power the will set into its own increase, and any appetite worn as a nature is a line run as a law. The hedonist bound by his craving, the tyrant by his dominion, are held as the saint is held by his mercy. That these wear the colors of self-assertion changes nothing. The Lehavah does not forbid the indulgent cut; it refuses the settling, and it carries what the law used to carry, the answer for the cut left with the one who draws it.

This whole distinction changes nothing for the Right-Hand Path. The difference we have drawn, between the shell sworn to as a rule and the shell struck as an act, between capture and the Lehavah, is a difference visible only from inside the work with the Qliphoth. It sorts the Left-Hand traditions from one another. The Holy Side sees none of it. It marks being on a single axis, whether the shell has been severed from the pure or not, and along that axis the Lehavah and the sworn inversion fall together on the same side, both still bound to the husk the ascent exists to cut away. To hold the cut open is, to that eye, to have failed to close it, which is the one failure the Right-Hand Path knows. For it the Lehavah is Qliphoth like any other, evil for the plain reason that evil has always meant the shell unremoved, and the will that keeps both faces alive is condemned for the amputation left undone.



CHAPTER 18. THE ACT

Every Qliphah carries the Sephirah it denies as the Sephirah's buried face. The underside cannot be the deep the Tree was cut from. The Tree left it behind: the cooled act with its sign reversed. A will sworn to the underside has taken the Tree's back for its front.

The Lehavah is something other than the Qliphoth raised to the same level or the two poles displayed where one was shown. To read it as content, limit and unbound set side by side and both kept, is to miss it: two poles held together is still what the cut produced. The Lehavah opens what lies before either pole: the act.

This act is at the origin of the Tree, under the gentler name. Before any Sephirah shines, Ain Soph contracts, and the tzimtzum clears a room for the world. Told as an act, it is the drawing of the first line, and the world is what it leaves behind. What follows is the kav, the ray let down into the cleared void, light descending to build the worlds along its length. The first move cuts through the undivided, setting this apart from that, and the worlds are created. Read this way, the Tree stops being a picture of light coming down and thinning and becomes a line leaving differences behind it, each Sephirah a place where the cut has fallen and a difference remains.

The summit is this act before it has settled into a number. The Tree sets Kether there, the One, and the Qliphoth answer with Thaumiel. Each is the cutting congealed toward a count, Kether the cut sworn to unity, Thaumiel the cut sworn to duality, and under both swearings is the cutting as such, no number at all, the drawing that yields one or two according to how it is held. Swearing the summit to a third number changes nothing in this. Deleuze set difference before identity and seated the many where the One had sat, and the many is a count like the one it unseated, difference enthroned as the ground where identity sat before.

Deleuze set the *rhizome* against the arborescent Tree, the sprawling many-rooted figure against the hierarchy, offered as the way out from under it. The figure was never where the binding lay. A rhizome held as a settled form dictates as surely as a Tree; its lines of flight are worn into channels a will runs without knowing it runs them, and once the sprawling shape is habitual it is one more residue read as the ontology. What frees is the regime under which any diagram is held, and no change of figure reaches it. What matters is whether the act stays transparent as act or sets into the figure and is lost in it. A Tree held as Lehavah is open; a rhizome gone to sediment is closed.

The act done, something stays where it fell. *Reshimu* is the trace, the remnant left in the void when the light drew back, and in Luria it is a residue of light, the faint impression the infinite leaves behind it after the contraction. Turn the word as the *tzimtzum* was turned. The *reshimu* is the trace of the act, what the cutting leaves when it is done, the deed cooled into form. The point is that the act became encounterable as a mark. A station of the Tree is *reshimu* in this sense, a cut gone to trace and waiting to be found, and the residue we have followed from the first is the tradition's remnant read for what it is.

The act is not secondary here, and this is worth marking. The tradition holds that the world hangs on acts, that a deed done rightly raises a fallen spark and mends a broken vessel, that the cosmos is repaired or ruined by what a will does. *Tikkun* is this: the act is granted the power to remake being, and creation is left unfinished so that the act can finish it. So far we agree with the tradition that the act is what the structure rests on. Then it turns the admission back. The act it honors is one that gathers, and the only act it will call holy is one bent toward the return. Repair is an act conscripted, the cutting power set to work undoing its own cuts, the difference raised only to be dissolved. But the act does not serve repair. Repair is the attempt to make the act labor against difference, to spend the power that lays distinctions on erasing them.

A trace can be held two ways. The will points at the reshimu and takes it for its nature, sinking into the sediment it left. Or it points at the cutting and holds itself as the act, keeping the trace as its deed. This second pointing is the true Name: the act indicating itself as act. The Name adds no station and no content. It is the act's reference back to itself, the hold by which a will stays the cutting it performed rather than the residue it dropped.

Tradition keeps the Name at the origin, though it is read toward the One. Asked for its name, the God of Exodus answers *Ehyeh asher Ehyeh*, a form of the verb to be folded back, a saying that names the saying and carries no content beneath it. The Kabbalists' word for the four-letter Name is *Havayah*, being, the Name that speaks the bare is and predicates no quality of it. This is the Name meant here as the act's self-reference. Ehyeh belongs to Kether, where the act first froze toward unity, and the seal that hardened the crown into Ratzon hardened the Name into the Name of the One, the self-saying taken for the self-designation of a source. Lift that seal and the crown's Name appears as it first was, the act's naming of itself, owing nothing to the source it was made to designate.

Once no nature lies under the act, the will and its Name come almost to unity, held apart only by the holding. The will is the cut kept as a deed, pointing at itself by Name. There is no gap between them for a nature to fill.

A will without a Name does not stay a will at large. It goes one of the two ways the account has marked. It can slacken until the cut relaxes and no distinction remains, and the undivided takes it back, the peace won by having no edge left. Or it can settle into the trace it dropped and read the cooled cut as what it is, the fall into residue. Then the Name cools with it, dropping from an act that holds itself to a sign that labels a fixed thing, and the sign most often marks a function. The Almighty names a will settled into an attribute, power read as the

being that has it. Louis the Fourteenth is a will worn down to a numbered office, the person read off the seat he filled, the name a slot the role fills and not an act anyone performs. The stations the Tree counts are names of the second kind, cuts lapsed into the marks they fixed. The residue was never anything but name dropped out of the act into the deposit. The Name is the holding that is neither, the will keeping its cut live without loosening it into the deep or freezing it into a nature.

The world is names through and through. There is the will, which is the act naming itself, and there is the sediment, which is that same naming gone to content, and nothing lies outside the two, because outside the will and its trace there is nothing at all. What the cut leaves behind is a spread of names, a few held live and the rest cooled into stations.

The word "name" has to be guarded from the ear that hears speech in it. The Name is no word laid over the world by a speaker, and a world of names is no text and no play of marks that point past themselves without end. The Name is the act's hold upon itself, the way a cut stays present as the cutting it is. It does its work before it is ever sounded, and the letters the tradition tallies are the late and audible edge of a self-reference that held in silence, in the bare presence of an act.

The Kabbalah read the *Torah* as the body of the world and held it to be nothing but the Great Name of God, one long unfolding of that Name, a fabric woven of the epithets in which the four-letter Name opens out. Gikatilla, in Scholem's account, had it that all *Torah* is a commentary upon the one Name and is built on that single ground. Vital drew the mechanism out: every limb of the order carries its own name, and at the heart of each sits the four-letter Name, letting each particular name govern a single limb while the one Name governs throughout, present in all of them as the soul is present in the body. Take the *Torah*

for the order of what is, and the claim is that being is spelled out as the Name, letter and combination down to the last station.

One text out of that stream says it and shows the trap in one motion. Idel gives it anonymously and places it near Isaac of Acre, and it has the will come forth from the source as the source's own name, and it calls that name Havayah. The identification could not be closer: the will that acts is the Name. Then the passage seals it. Before the world was made, it says, He and His name were one, the Name folded into the source at the origin and never let out from under it. The stations below are the source's instruments, and they have need of him while he has no need of them, and the naming is gathered back into one Name belonging to a One beneath it as its ground. That is the seal, the Name read toward the source, folded into the self-saying of the height.

The tradition undoes the seal with its other hand. Vital sets at the summit an Emanator that has no image and no name, no letter and not so much as the tips of letters, a source one may not even think. Naming begins a step down, with the first emanation, and never reaches the source at all. Follow that where it goes. If the source bears no name, the Name is not its own, and what starts only with emanation starts with the cut. The act comes first, and the Name is the act keeping hold of itself. Vital lodged this order inside the tradition: the origin is nameless, and naming is the first thing the act does.

Lift it as it was lifted at the crown, and the identification holds while the ground falls away. The will is the Name, and there is no One whose Name it is, no source that all the names spell. What remains is names in the plural, each a will with the trace it lets fall, and no single Name seated under them to gather them. Fichte's *Tathandlung*, the act that posits itself and is nothing before the positing, is this Name reached from another road.

This also holds against enthroning the deep. To say the truth beneath is two where the Tree said one, and to seat that two as the ground, is to

lay a name cold again and build the Tree once more with a higher count. The act refuses the throne by its nature, since a throne is a settled form and the act is the refusal to settle. It is held and performed, not established; and the moment it is founded it is the Tree.

CHAPTER 19. THE UNFALLEN

The first trace an act leaves is *time*. Before the cut there is no before and no after, nothing set in a row: a sequence needs two terms told apart and the cut is what first tells them. Time is the act's residue, the first sediment the act sheds, older than the world it goes on to deposit.

The oldest cosmology in the tradition puts time where we put it. The *Sefer Yetzirah* counts the registers of formed being as three and sets them side by side: *olam*, *shanah*, *nefesh*, world and year and soul, space and time and life. Time is there at the origin beside the world and the person, one of the three axes along which the formless is cut into the formed, not a container the other two sit in. The self is coeval with the cut, and the act lays all three at once. And the later doctrine confesses this when it speaks of a before and an after to the *tzimtzum*, then takes the words back: the Chabad masters warn that the before and after of the contraction are no ordinary times but terms of order, marking the divide between the primal manifestation and the created relation. They reach for temporal words to name what founds time and know the words cannot be literal, as time is on the near side of the act.

Place is deposited no less than time. Before the cut there is no here and no elsewhere, no this at a remove from that, and the cut that draws a center off from what surrounds it is what first sets a here against an elsewhere. The where and the when fall in the one stroke, on the near side of the act together. Causation is laid the same way. Before the cut nothing follows from anything, since a consequence needs two terms told apart and a direction between them, and the cut is what first tells

them and sets the order. Cause and effect are the act's residue as much as time is. And the one and the many are laid there too: before the line falls there is neither a unit to count nor a plurality to gather, and the cut is what first makes a this to be one or many.

Once time is the act's residue, the labor of return shows its last ambition. Tikkun gathers the sparks and mends the vessels, and it does this across history, deed after deed, until the mending is complete. When the repair is finished, Lawrence Fine observes, the historical process reaches its end; there is no more time, as there is nothing left to mend and no distance left to cross. Tikkun wants an end to time. The repair that undoes difference undoes with it the sequence difference made, and the reward held out at the close of the work is the cessation of it, the falling-still of the process, the return to a state where nothing happens because nothing is apart. Repair is the war on time as much as on evil, and it is one war, since the time and the evil are the same difference under two names.

The act deposits, then, and a will has no nature under it to stand on. It must hold to something, and there are only two things to hold. It can hold to the residue, follow the settled cut and let it lead, and then the deposit becomes its nature: the will lives inside a time and a causation and a world some act laid down, taking that frame for the given and itself for a thing inside it. This is the Demiurge, the will that laid a world and then took the trace of its own cutting for the law it must obey, and it runs on the scale of a soul as much as a cosmos, in any will that meets its hardened habit and calls it fate. To hold the residue is to live in a borrowed frame as though no will had drawn it.

A will that does not fasten to its deposit has one thing left to hold, its own act, and holds by pointing at the cutting, closing on the deed it performs and remaining itself through that closure. This is the Name, the act bent back on itself, a groundless will kept a will by holding the one thing that is its own. The deposit is there, real as any world, the

lower stations set down as surely as the Tree sets them; the will is simply not lost in them. The crown showed this at a single station, but the fall is not confined there. Any act can be held so, any residue owned as a deed rather than obeyed. What the unsealed crown was for the summit, the Name is for any act whatsoever.

This is apotheosis. To be a god is not to dwell at the peak of unity, the point all the lower stations climb toward, for that peak is the sealed crown, the deepest fall wearing the face of the height. To be a god is to live in the act and not in its result, to lay a world and not be ruled by it.

In the *Cratylus* Plato has Socrates trace *theos* to *theein*, to run, holding that the first namers called the gods so because they saw the divine things forever in motion, sun and stars that never rest, and named godhood after the running. The etymology is no philology; it is a listening, the kind that hears in a worn word what the usage buried. Godhood was named for movement and then enshrined as the most motionless thing there is, the fixed point at the summit where all motion comes to rest. The buried sense holds against the doctrine that covered it: to be a god is to be in the act that does not stop. *Theos* is the will in motion, and the crown is *theos* stilled into an idol.

Apotheosis cannot be a *telos*, for a *telos* is a nature reached and rested in, a settling into what one finally is. It is not a state a will arrives at and keeps. It is a stance held against the will's perpetual settling, the act occupied and reoccupied, godhood as the refusal to become the god.

The emptiness set at the summit was misnamed. It was called *Ain*, the nothing above the Crown, and read in the two ways taken apart above, as the veil through which the infinite becomes a source and as the blank the tradition threw over Tiamat to keep her from being called a rival. There is a third *Ain*, and it is the true one. The true emptiness is the groundlessness a will comes to know when it sees that under its cutting there is no law, nothing beneath the act that told it to fall here.

To be a god is to be the cut that knows it is arbitrary and wills anyway, the act held in its bottomlessness and drawing the line from there, sovereign because nothing under it commands and nothing above it approves. The height was always the will, emptied of every ground.

CHAPTER 20. WILLS AND WORLDS

If Qliphoth and the cut beneath them are moves of a will, the Tree can look as if it has shrunk to psychology, a theater of figures a mind runs internally, and the powers of the Nightside with it, its demons and its gates dwindling to images in a private interior.

The objection rests on a partition it keeps out of sight. It sets a material world outside and a psyche within it, granting the outside the real and leaving the inside a faint copy, so that anything done on the side of the image is filed as something felt, with the doing reserved to the outside. That partition is the materialist settlement: the world given over to matter, the leftover interior transferred to a science of the inside, and psychology is the name of the leftover. To ask whether the working is only psychological is to have signed that settlement, since the question grants matter its monopoly on the real.

The Left-Hand Path cosmology never signed it. There are wills, which are acts, and there is Tiamat, the undivided that no act has yet cut. A world is what a will deposits in acting, so a Sephirah is no image dimmed against a solid substrate, there being no matter behind it to serve as one. Tiamat cannot serve as the solid thing either, holding no determination for an image to copy, and the empty nothing the Tree named her was false. What is determinately real is deposited will and nothing else. The Tree is will taken for the structure of being; the Nightside is will taken for its underside.

What happens between worlds is the meeting of the wills that laid them. A will leaves a deposit in cutting, and beyond that deposit it

does one thing: it meets another will, pressing on it, gathering it, drawing it into its own line or breaking against it. Existence is wills, the sediment their cutting leaves, and the pressure of will upon will. The Demiurge's dominion is no more than this: a will that gathers other wills, so that they take its sediment for the ground of the world. No further principle is needed to account for the Tree's reign, and none is there to find.

Deposited will is objective in the single sense the word can carry here. It remains where it was laid, it resists the will that meets it, and it belongs to the one who laid it. A will entering a deposited world meets a cut it did not draw, and the resistance of that cut to its wishes is the mark that the cut is not its own. The Sitra Achra is objective in just this way.

The Sephirotic diagram was never a set of private mental pictures. To the Kabbalist a Sephirah is a power and an emanation, a name of the hidden God and a root of existence, and the diagram is the way into a hidden life that yields to no more literal telling. The symbol is the access to a reality, used because the concealed answers to nothing plainer. Put a form of will in the place of the hidden God the access reaches, and the refusal of psychologism carries over whole. The symbol is how the hidden is reached, as the hidden appears under no other form.

Vital in *Gates of Holiness* set down how this is seen, and his account leaves no room for the reduction. He has the practitioner's thought climb the levels to the root of the soul, and the light then descends back through him until the imaginative power sets it into a worldly image, met as though by the outer senses, at times as an angel that speaks. The imaginative power shapes the descending light; it does not invent what it shapes. The seer serves as a link in a chain of worlds, drawing the abundance down through himself before any portion of it becomes his own, so that the vision is a current that passes through a

subject on its way. Lift the upward aim from this, the light let down from the One and the repair the descent is bent to serve, and the working structure stays: the seer is a passage in a chain, and the access runs through levels already there before him. Reseat the chain on what we hold and its levels are the deposits of wills, its current one will's cut crossing into the working of another, the passage a way opened between acts.

No will meets a bare reality, because there is no bare reality to be met. Tiamat is met by no one, and all else is already cut. A will has a world only through the cuts that give it one, through the names and differences by which it sorts what it faces, and the pulls and refusals that set it toward this and away from that. A Sephirah is a form of will, and its image is the way that form comes to hand, the shape under which it can be worked at all. Pain is had through the body and forfeits no reality for being felt there; a form of will is had through its image and forfeits none for being worked there.

The instrument of the practice, whatever name the map gives it, gathers a scattered will into one gesture and holds it there. What moves when the gesture takes is the cut: what counts as one's own and what as foreign, what as barred and what as open to the hand. The cut is the founding act, and a world is a cut set down; to shift the cut is to shift the world the will has. The working reaches past the picture of a settled world into the line along which a world is laid. Held as Lehavah the cut is shifted in the open, owned in the shifting; held as sediment it is served.

Jung's labor halts on the near side of that line. He takes the disowned face back into a self and names the larger figure complete, and the taking-back does ease a person, quieting the war he had waged on his psyche. The dark he reclaims is an attractor, and to accept it as a content of the self quiets the quarrel over the vector while the vector runs on, since the labor falls on the image and never reaches the cut.

He keeps the interior the materialist handed him and tends it in good order. The practice meant here moves the line the interior was cut from, and a will that moves that cut is no longer drawn where it was drawn before.

The Other Side opens as more than a man's own depths costumed as gods. Its powers are the deposits of the wills that the Tree never gathered in, as real as the Tree and beholden to it in nothing.

CHAPTER 21. THE OTHER KINGDOM

The powers of the Other Side stand outside the Tree's descent, and the tradition that feared them most is the one that gave them a court. In the first full account of the left emanation, Isaac ha-Kohen set Samael and Lilith as king and queen over the powers of the deep, a wedded pair answering the holy bride and groom, and Joseph Dan reads the myth as built on that answering, the dark couple laid against Adam and Eve and against the King and his Presence. Yet the sources never settle what her seat is. Isaac sets her as the consort at Samael's side, the female half of a demonic pair, and Scholem marks this pairing with Samael as the properly Kabbalistic innovation, older legend having known her as the night-demon who kills infants and endangers women in childbirth. In that pairing she is queen of the realm of the shells, filling there the function the Shekhinah fills in the world of sanctity, mother of the impure as the Presence is mother of Israel, the dark answer to the indwelling Presence. Her rank sits oddly even so. She is named the king's consort and the queen of a whole realm, and the two titles pull against each other, sovereign in her own domain yet given as one half of a pair.

Berman finds this instability at the root of the Zoharic split. The myth Rabbi Shimon reveals to the few is that the divine King, who should be joined to his Presence, is joined instead to a diabolical consort, and the terror of the disclosure is that divine and demonic can no longer be

told apart, the holy marriage and its dark double grown indistinguishable at the very point the text works hardest to keep them two. The Zohar draws the border and dissolves it in the drawing. It cannot drive her past the wall, because the King it would purify is wed to her.

This unbinds the verdict. If the tradition's text cannot keep her outside as a clean enemy, if she appears inside the holy marriage as its underside, no foe beyond a wall, then evil is the name unity presses on her out of its failure to be rid of her. She is the difference the one could neither gather in nor cut away completely. The Lehavah reached this, the stance that answers to neither the bright pole nor the dark and burns between them. Lilith is that stance given a throne, the difference held open where the Tree would have closed it.

The Tree is a deduction, and a deduction can be counted. Ten Sephiroth are set rank behind rank, each one reached by the one above and held in its place by the descent that derives it, and the count holds because deriving and being taken up are the work of unity, which lays its differences out as numbered stations and keeps them told. To number is already to have sublated, to fix a one and set the next against it in order. The Other Side is what that work never reached, and will not be counted.

The doctrine betrays this each time it reaches for the rank of Lilith. She is the queen of the deep, one sovereign over the shells, and she is the wife of Samael, one of a pair. Called single, she doubles into the couple; called double, she draws back into the one crown, and the sources never close the question because the question has no seat in her. The dragon stream that maps the shells stumbles at that place from the other side. It sets twin gods at the summit of the Qliphoth, Satan and Moloch, two faces turned opposite ways, and then unsays the two, making them the masks of a single hooded Lord whose true face is the Void, a three that is neither the two it shows nor the one it hides.

Mason draws the crown as this shifting number, and the shifting is the truth of it, a count that slides the moment it is fixed. Call the summit one and the two rise through it; call it two and the one draws them back; the third names not a sum but the refusal to settle at either. Even the Christian Trinity carried this, held for centuries as a number no council could resolve without heresy on one side or the other, one substance that would not reduce to three and three persons that would not collapse to one.

The Draconian current reads its sliding as an arrival. The three becomes a true face, the Void behind the hood, a one that has absorbed the two, and with that the shells become a ladder again and the summit a crown reached and kept. This is the counter-Tree in its reversed dress, a deduction climbing to a black apex, the settling refused throughout. The number slides because nothing beneath it sublates it into a total, and to seat it at last in a hooded one is to do the crown's work on the Other Side.

To fix Lilith outside as a clean enemy would resolve the two sides into a sealed border, and to enthrone her as the one queen would set a single crown against Ain Soph, and both ask the count to hold still. A seal closes a result, a difference told and put to rest, and here there is no settled number to close upon. What cannot be told as one or two cannot be sealed as either, and the sovereignty that holds by staying uncounted gives the sealing no purchase.

The count the Tree keeps and the Other Side loses is drawn nowhere more plainly than in the act the tradition made its central image, the joining of male and female. On the Tree that joining resolves. The King couples with his Presence, the Shekhinah is drawn up out of her exile and gathered to her lord, and the two that stood apart close into the one flow the coupling restores. Idel describes the structure raised as an anatomy that works as a pair of male and female powers, joined to bring forth a fruit, the world and the souls in it, difference put to work

and consummated in what it issues. Scholem finds the rite below lifted to sustain the marriage above, the human act stirring the sacred coupling and drawing the parted powers back into one. The eros of the Tree is *zivug*, the right pairing whose end is to shut the two into unity.

On the Other Side the same pair remains and the shutting is withheld. Samael and Lilith couple and come to no single crown, and Lilith does not thin into a transparent Presence spent in her lord. She holds as consort and queen, the receiving side that is never taken up, the female the union cannot exhaust. Berman reads a passage where a spirit of seduction settles from Lilith over Yesod, the Foundation, and covers it, so that the holy power gathered there does not pass from what it could be into what it does. A turban veils the divine phallus, a foreskin drawn over the source, and the flow the Tree's marriage exists to loose is stopped at its issue. What comes of this is called a brood of destroyers, a ruin of the worlds above and below, because the tradition weighs the act by the union it failed to complete. Weighed from the difference the act keeps open, the blockage is a coupling that declines to resolve: an eros that joins without fusing and divides without parting, one flesh that stays two and a two that never counts apart. Where the Tree's union raises the Shekhinah and closes the breach, this joining holds the union open in the difference, neither sinking the two into one nor letting them fall back into two, and keeps Lilith sovereign within it, a queen no marriage absorbs.

This is why the act falls under law wherever unity rules, and the law bends one way. It licenses the coupling that issues in one and forbids the rest, confining eros into the single sanctioned channel where two are made into one flesh and one household, the seed loosed toward its fruit and the difference spent in the joining. Where the law is Christian it runs the bending to its end. Continence is set above the licensed union, the unparted state held nearer the one than any coupling can reach, and at the last a risen world is drawn where they neither marry nor are given in marriage, the pairing undone and the difference

between them annulled. That summit is sexless, the body's division wiped away, the pull toward the one carried onto the flesh with nothing left to check it, and it marks the far pole.

The Kabbalah ranks eros under the one by another route, for in it sex reaches into the godhead and outlasts the body. Berman reads the Sephiroth as gendered persons coupling in pairs, with the Supernal Father and Mother above in Chokhmah and Binah, and the parting and rejoining of the lower pair as the central drama the whole mythology turns on. Sex belongs to the structure of the divine, and the death of the body leaves it standing where the risen world lets it fall.

At death the body drops the division and leaves sex standing. Scholem finds in the Zohar a soul composite of male and female at its root, split into masculine and feminine only in the descent into a human frame, and he reads the world of souls it returns to as the recovery of the state it held before that descent. There the soul keeps its own standing and is not gathered into the Divine. It comes home to the undivided form, male and female folded in one and not yet drawn apart, an androgyne that has shed the split the body imposed and holds within it everything the split had divided.

This homecoming is still the gathering into one. The androgyne root is a wholeness in which the two have not become two, the division healed, the male and female held as one undivided form, and the soul that reaches it comes back to a unity the body had only borrowed. Against the coupling the Other Side enthrones, the two that stay two and fold into no single form, the androgyne stands on unity's side of the line, one form recovered by undoing the split where the Other Side keeps the difference it never folds back in. The law that governs eros is the descent come down onto the body, and the ways beyond the body it holds out, the sexless summit and the undivided root alike, are the descent's last reach onto the flesh, each a homecoming into one.

The Zohar left one figure it could not parse, the ten powers of the Other Side clinging to the slime of the Shekhinah's fingernail, and Berman marks how little sense it makes, that so slight a leaving should bear a world entire. It makes none by the Tree's measure, where a kingdom hangs on rank and descent. The kingdom holds by the contrary binding, wills held together in a strife that resolves into neither order nor union, and what could carry no world on the Tree's terms carries one on its own.

The difference unity failed to admit could be kept as a nameless lack, the loss carried in grief and never given a face, and that apophatic way with the irreducible is not the one taken here. Seated, Lilith is the difference affirmed, real and ruling, and the impurity read into her marks the will the one could not absorb, her sovereignty the very failure the order indicted as a crime.

CHAPTER 22. THE BURNING

Seeing the cut that ranks the sides can look like a reason to withdraw from both, to rise above the pull of light and dark in a stillness that wants neither. That stillness would be the will's undoing. The quiet above the opposites, the letting-go that reaches for nothing, is the return to the undivided the ascent offered under holier names. Lehavah takes a form, dark in one hour and bright in the next, moves, and changes as the hour asks. What it will not do is let a form set into a law of the self.

This lies at the far end of a range the tradition walks without a name for the end of it. One worker goes down into the dark current and takes what it raises in him, the fear and the coming-apart, the presences that meet him there, and his work rests for the most part on the residue. Another keeps to the accepted face, its order and the discipline of the upward way, and moves inside the Tree. A third draws on both at once, weighing light against dark and taking the disowned side back to make

himself complete, and he comes nearer, though he settles where the Tree lets him settle, in the reconciliation of opposites.

The one who works the Lehavah has seen the stroke that made the two sides two, the cut that raised one face into the holy and pressed the other down as the foul, and once that stroke is seen there is nothing left to weigh. He acts out of a dark form or a bright one, holds the form he is in as a line he drew and can draw again and keeps the cut it makes open under his hand.

The first three keep to a chart, one Tree worked from both its faces. The bright stations and the buried ones are a single structure, and the roster of shells the practitioner climbs is the Tree's sediment laid out as a country to cross. The dark ascent walks that Tree from behind, the mixing of light and dark holds its two faces at once, and neither steps off the ground the Demiurge set down. The deep keeps no chart of its own, holding no rung to set, present as the cut before any map has ranked its sides.

Every determination the descent laid down was a cut held as its result, a line taken for the shape of being and obeyed, and the tyranny the tradition suffered under and called holiness was the reign of the sealed cut. Before this reign we have found only two exits, dissolving the cut or sealing it harder, and both surrender the difference the sealing buried. The Lehavah is the third for which the Tree left no room: the single stance that keeps the difference the descent was built to bury.

The will there is a god by the only measure we can give the word. Lehavah names a will awake in its cutting, owning each line it lays and lifting it the moment it hardens into a rule. Apotheosis reaches here the sense the crown prefigured, a stance that never sets, godhood carried as a motion and lost the moment it is set down as a state. The freedom in it is the freedom of an act that declines to become a law, and first refuses to make that refusal into a law.

To lay out the Qliphoth as a course with a final grade is to miss what the ascent was for. A curriculum runs from the uninitiated bottom up through the shells, past the Abyss taken as one station among others, to a summit where a god title is conferred and a new world is entered, and arrival is built into its frame, a terminus a will reaches and then dwells in. To dwell in a reached world is to have fallen into it, the settling we refuse, and a godhood handed over at the end of a syllabus is one more grade, one more line the will is set on and told to run. The Abyss is no station cleared and left behind. It remains the open seam at every determination, crossed nowhere once and for all.

The currents crown this arrival with a godhood, and the prize comes in two castings. Karlsson casts it as escape: the initiate throws off God and the spent creation, crosses Thaumiel into Universe B, and stands there a creator, sovereign over a world that answers to him. Mason, in the *Draconian Ritual Book*, casts it as ingestion: the powers of the gods are drawn into the body and made the practitioner's own, the seer who glimpsed godhood has grown into it and stands at the last as "God Incarnate," heavy with the force he has absorbed. One holds a world of his own, the other keeps all power in his own hand, and both fix the godhood at the head of a ladder as a rank the will attains and keeps.

What that rank contains is never said. No worked philosophy stands under the apparatus to fix whether the godhood is the massing of powers into one will or some further thing the word only points at. The vagueness has a cause. What these promises reach for is met and proven mostly beyond death, past the reach of any account a living hand sets down, and a current is not to be blamed for leaving unspoken what only dying confirms. Yet where the thing is left in fog the fog does its own work, and the godhood settles in the reader as a place gained and held, a station a self climbs to and then inhabits.

Attained and kept, the godhood is a result set down by the will. A god ranked by the powers he has taken in is a will made vast and bound the

tighter for its mass, a heading run to its end. A god throned as maker in a private world has become a Demiurge. Each is the will frozen at a summit and declared to have arrived, and a will that has arrived is a flame gone to ash. *Liber Azerate* at least owns this. It offers no god who survives the crossing, setting the acausal Chaos as its end and the pouring of the self back into the formless as its work, and hiding none of it. The honesty saves nothing, since naming the ash is not escaping it, yet it alone declines to gild the ash as flame. What none of them holds is the godhood that is no rank at all, the will alive in its cutting and settling into no throne, above or below.

Bataille worked from this too and followed it to a different end. What frees cannot be hoarded, cannot be banked into a holding a subject keeps and draws on, and sovereignty lives in the moment that breaks from use and spends without return. He read that moment as loss, the sovereign instant dissolving the one who reaches it, freedom tasted as a small death where the self comes apart in the excess. The premise holds and the paths divide at the self. That the act cannot be kept as a possession does not spend the will away in it; it remains in the act, kept whole in the very gesture it cannot bank. Bataille has the self undone in the expenditure and the deep has it affirmed, the sovereign moment held as the subject's truest holding.

One charge is left: the book seems to hand the weapon against its own claim. If all is cut, the book is cut too. Every line here was drawn by a will and bound by nothing to be drawn, so the account is contingent as everything is, one stroke among the strokes that might have fallen otherwise, resting on no ground it did not lay. By its own word it saws through the branch it sits on.

The charge trades on two senses of the contingent held as one. A cut is contingent in its source: no nature under the will commanded the line to fall here, and the will was free not to lay it. This is true of the book without remainder. It was written by a will that need not have written

it and need not have cut as it did. Nothing follows from this about the truth of what the cut lays out, any more than a thing seen truly turns false because the eye might have been shut. The dogmatist's answer carries all of it: an absence of ground under the act is not an absence of object before it, and that this account rests on no commanding necessity is one more instance of what it reports, not a crack in it.

For the will does not cut in a vacuum, and this is what the charge forgets. The first cut was laid so, the stroke into the undivided that met no formed thing and fell where nothing resisted it, and the undivided still enters through the seam and offers a later blade the same unresisting depth. But this is not where most of our cutting falls. Whoever draws a line draws it in the Demiurge's cosmos, and for the most part it meets what is already there, the world, the ascent that sublates, the Other Side that will not be counted. These were not invented by the drawing. They are struck against: the sediments a later will runs into and cannot pass through by wishing, older and heavier than the stroke that meets them. To cut freely is to lay a line and feel where it catches, not to have the field give way and take any shape the hand prefers.

The book is a cut and it is not alone in its kind. The materialist cuts the same material and so does the Christian, each laying the world out along lines of his own, and the account given here takes its place among them as one more stroke, not above them as the report they failed to file. What sets a stroke apart from a caprice is not that it was drawn by no will (for they all were), but that it must pass what a caprice never faces.

The first thing it must pass is the world's resistance. A line can be laid anywhere, but not every one is held by what it falls across. Say the world is a dream and the saying can be maintained, yet the world resists it throughout, behaving nowhere as a dream behaves, so that the cut survives only by an endless labor of explaining the resistance

away. Such a doctrine can hold, but it holds eccentrically, paying at every turn a price the world exacts for a line it will not easily bear. Resistance sorts the cuts by what each costs to hold against the ground it crosses.

What survives that test has still to hold together. A cut the world tolerates can tear internally, running two moves that cannot hold at once, denying at one seam what it asserts at another. The reverse cut of the tradition pays its price both here and in the resistance, forced to expel its sediment and name it alien, mounting a repair that cannot end for the edge keeps bearing what the edge denies. A map that must disown its own workings to stay a map has failed the second test as surely as the dream-cut failed the first.

These two sift the strokes down to a few, and among these the sifting stops. More than one holds. The materialist's account coheres and is borne, at the price of handing matter all of the real and leaving no ground for what a will deposits; this account coheres and is borne, at the price of refusing sublation. No further test ranks the survivors; what divides them is no longer a question of the truth. It is a question of what the will wants: unity or the two, the rest of the One or the sovereignty of what it could not gather. The tradition wanted unity and wrote its wanting as necessity, the world as it must be. We want the difference and know the wanting for a cut.

That the last word falls to the will is not the flaw but its edge. There is nothing under the will to make the choice for it, and this is the Ain met before, the groundlessness that is the will's own. We reach the floor where any account must, at a will electing the cut it will live by, and our account differs from its rivals in one respect: that it says so. It does not offer itself as the truth that ends the choosing. We show a cut a will makes toward difference with eyes open, declining to seal that choice into a necessity and call the seal the final truth.

The work offers no throne, and the missing throne is all it has to teach. There is no crossing that stays crossed. The will lives only in the standing, renewed at each cut and lost the hour the hand goes slack, and this is a labor with no resting place in it.

The Sitra Achra was never a country to reach. The act is done here, wherever a will draws a line and refuses to obey it.

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